

BEHIND BARBED WIRE

Foreword (to the 1st Edition)
Pocatello (Idaho), 24 Dec., 1945

What this book offers the reader is so understandable that it actually requires no foreword. If an introduction is nevertheless placed before the book, it is only out of the consideration that the reader must absolutely know something about the origin of the story, for it is itself no less characteristic than the individual events depicted in the book, and deserves to be reported.

"Behind Barbed Wire in America" arose from the wish to make a joint gift to a small, select community. That in doing so, everyone took on a part of the total work according to talent and disposition is only natural. And so, thanks to the most eager efforts of all participants, this humorous report of experiences was created. It is the history of our captivity in America; it is the history of the POW's [Prisoners of War] par excellence.

Admittedly, the book in its current form deviates far from the original planning. From "a collection of funny Christmas occurrences," which began with the "Benedictus," became a factual report of our POW life. It was an unintended development, but the topic proved to be so rewarding and advantageous that all forces began with the creation. And if one now considers the artistic value that our book represents, the change was only to be welcomed.

If I now state the names of all participants at the beginning of our book, I would like to pay off a small part of my debt of gratitude to them for their eager work towards complete success. Ernst-Günther Höffer took over the illustration of the poems and stories. That he wrote a large number of the verses himself, should only be mentioned in passing. Which is more to the point, his caricatures or his witty verses, I leave to the judgment of the reader. Anyone who has seen him at his work knows about the primitive conditions and appreciates his work all the more. The author of most of the stories is Alois Klug. His great experience pointed out many an advantageous path during the creation of the book. The work of printing and duplication was taken over by Helmut Kaufmann and Willi König. Without their laborious work, the book would never have been created in this form and to this extent. At the same time, their literary contributions must not be forgotten, which considerably increased the value of our book. Rudolf König also donated a series of contemplative anecdotes, which lend the book a special note.

The individual contributions were compiled taking into account the chronological sequence. Thus our book came into being. Many hours full of cheerfulness and humor are recorded therein. They testify to the attitude and the firm will of the prisoners of war. And this will shall also let them master the difficulties of the future one day.

And now I give the book into the hands of our community. May everyone in good and bad times remember the happy hours reported here. Then the memory of us and Christmas 1945 will always persist.

THE BENEDICTUS IN THE HOLY NIGHT

As a young high school student on high feast days, I played the second violin in the choir of our village church with my friend Hieronymus, called Ronymus for short. The choir director was the old head teacher, from whom we had both learned to read, write, and calculate.

Christmas Eve was approaching. Ronymus and I were looking forward to the old, handwritten Christmas mass that was to be sung and played for the Midnight Mass. After the simple but intimate celebration at home, we both slept for a little hour. When it was time for Mass, our mother had trouble waking us from our healthy young sleep.

Bravely we trudged through snow and storm up the village street to the church, from which all bells were inviting to the service. The High Mass began. We blissfully fiddled the shepherd melodies, and even if many a note fell under the desk, we kept up bravely. The most beautiful part of the mass, the Benedictus, came. We wanted to fiddle it with all heartiness, but soon we heard with astonishment that our tones did not fit the overall picture at all; the tempo also gave us difficulty. But not only us, others heard it too; first my father, who sang the bass. He turned around and cast us an angry look. I noticed it and stopped. But since my Ronymus fiddled on bravely, I could not leave him and fiddled again. Now the girls from the soprano, who were just pausing, giggled; the head teacher squinted angrily over the rims of his glasses from the organ at us; the trombone player shook his white head; the timpanist beat time for us; nothing helped. I saw the surroundings, sweated with excitement, but did not leave my friend, who played on cheerfully, alone and helped him faithfully with wrong tones.

Now something bad happened. The Benedictus was over. The choir and the entire musical accompaniment fell silent - but Ronymus and I were not yet at the end, a number of notes still wanted to be played. I looked at my friend, he at me, and then we stopped our solo playing.

The conductor Vinz, who played the first violin, was already standing by us, and since Ronymus was his student, he said quite unfriendly: "You boys, what have you been fiddling?" Wordlessly I pointed to our section. He paused for a moment, then he laughed and showed my father, who had also come, our sheet of music; he too smirked. Since the first female singer also felt compelled to laugh at us, I said to the conductor: "What is there to laugh about?" Cousin Vinz gently pulled my earlobe, pointed to the notes and said: "You two learn Latin in high school and now ---" with that he pointed to the heading - the letters blurred before my eyes with fright, for there stood broad and massive **Agnus Dei** and we should have played the **Benedictus**. We were ashamed. When the turn came for the Agnus Dei, we had

had some practice and it therefore worked magnificently.

Our mistake could not disturb the good mountain people in their Christmas joy, and I suspect, also not in the little nap that overtook many during the mass. And I believe, even the Child in the Manger only smiled and accepted our good will, for soon after we slept - Ronymus and I - peacefully and happily into the Christmas Morning.

LAND IS IN SIGHT

That hour was long ago,
when we strolled a round
on the ship and heard the news:
Land is in sight!
A milestone in our life,
quite a few felt it with trembling,
this moment has yielded:
Land is in sight!

Kirchner

THE WAY TO TEXAS

Deloused and searched everywhere,
perhaps also cursed quite often,
thus we boarded the train in Boston
and drove into the country.
Past innumerable cities,
through woods, over mountains and valleys,
through fields, meadows, large and wide
and over broad highways,
often past negro huts;
we also saw all sorts of other things:
the Erie Lake and the Missouri,
America's reception potpourri.
So it went during day and night,
the eyes are hardly closed,
the call sounds, "you must see this,"
the neon signs big and beautiful,
the cars, surely a thousand pieces,
there I thought, I'm going crazy.
A wealth so great and unequalled,
but also misery, often heartbreaking.
A colorful picture was our journey,
even if travel hardships were
hard and unbearable,
thus we drove into the country.
Rochester, Syracuse and Dallas,
more beautiful than in the most beautiful atlas.

Thus we saw the new land,
previously known only to a few.
And on and on drove the train,
quite a few had already had enough.
But finally we were at the goal,
of the City we did not see much.
A small village in the wide South,
where even in winter the flowers
bloom. There was the wire,
behind which we were imprisoned.
Fort Sam Houston was the name of the camp,
- Kenedy – was the name of the town
but at first this was all the same,
for the heat made us weak.
Later, during many weeks,
many an offense was committed.
Some of them we will describe
now in words and in pictures.

Kirchner

THE LAXATIVE PILLS

I met my friend Paul Mueller from Ulm in the western tip of France, in that area of Brittany which is washed by the open ocean and is denominated by the French as "Land's End". After the capture, we met again and since we are both older boys and belong to the guild of schoolmasters—he to the higher commercial school, I to the Secondary School - we stayed together, traveled together across the English Channel, lived in the same room in England, slept in a bunk bed, Paul on top, I below, sailed with a ship, which after all displaced some twenty thousand tons of water, across the Atlantic Ocean, were deloused in Boston and traveled from Monday to Friday from Boston on the train to Texas. A kind fate gave us a shared barrack, in which the two of us were to live in peace and harmony for eight months. My story begins with the crossing. When we were allowed on deck for the first time, the English mainland was just disappearing in a veil of mist. A Swedish steamer, recognizable as such from afar, lay at anchor. Three destroyers accompanied our zig-zag course, which we had to maintain because of the German U-boat danger. A fresh, strong wind blew, the sea drove quite high waves against our ship and although it showed massive bulk and rocked precariously, at any rate more than was beneficial for our landlubbers' stomachs. The food, served twice a day, was very good, but had to be consumed standing up, which was not easy with the movement of the ship. After the meal, I hurried downstairs as quickly as possible to get into a horizontal position, for - well, seasickness sat purring at my throat. While some comrades, like Willi Keckenstock, were already bringing Neptune their "sacrifice", I could leave my stomach contents to their natural course. That is admittedly not quite true. Although the sea became like a mirror and the danger of seasickness receded, I was and remained constipated, like a medieval cannon. It was probably a nervous matter, for, on the ship, I could not bring myself to use the

place visible to all the world. I had hoped for the train, but it didn't get better there. The Americans probably considered us German officers dangerous people, for on both platforms of the second-class carriage stood guards with loaded rifles and furthermore, an evil-looking soldier supervised the interior of the carriage and if we had to go to the toilet, we had to report like little schoolboys. The loo stood open, the door had been removed and a dense wire mesh had been woven over the window. In the face of the guard, I did not succeed in sitting on the loo, not out of fear of the gun - after all we came from combat - but I was simply embarrassed, like a young girl.

My friend Paul had caught a beard lichen on the journey, how and where, I do not know, in any case long stubble "adorned" his Swabian face, as if he were a candidate for the post of a robber captain.

Thus we both came to Kenedy in the State of Texas, not too far away from the Gulf of Mexico, and moved into our home. Paul had to go to the infirmary daily to have his lichen treated. He was smeared once with a white, then a yellow, later a red and finally a green ointment, no wonder if the lichen grew vigorously under this care and seemingly felt very well.

I wasn't doing particularly well either; I remained constipated, although I had gotten used to the open-standing loo. My friend Paul spoke English very well, while my language skills at that time were limited to one word and that was: "Let's go!" If we were supposed to move faster in the opinion of the Americans, it was: "Mach schnell, Officer!" or briefly "let's go!" I therefore asked my Paul: "When you go to get smeared again tomorrow, do tell Uncle Doctor he should send along some laxative pills for me." "Gladly," said my friend. The next morning Paul came back with a dark green ointment on his face, quickly threw away his blouse and disappeared. What is wrong with him?

After a while he came back, pale in the face. "Are you not well?" I asked anxiously. "Oh, imagine. When the doctor had anointed me, I told him in my most beautiful English that I was constipated, he should give me some pills. He asked, how long, I replied, for eight days. Then he shook his white head, fetched three pills, put aqua fontis, tap water, into a paper cup and handed me both. I wanted to pocket the pills for you, then he said I should take them immediately. My attempt to persuade him that it would be better at home failed due to his stubbornness, and so I, unlucky fellow, had to swallow this strong dose, although I was anything but constipated."

While I was still laughing, my Paul dashed off again to pay a longer visit to Aunt Meier (the toilet). He had to run a few more times until his bowels had calmed down again.

I laughed so much that the shaking helped me too, especially since I drank considerable amounts of water at the "Kolchose-innkeeper". Kolchose-innkeeper was the name of the font at the Russian barrack.

However, in my opinion, the forced cure helped my friend Paul as much as the rainbow-colored ointments, for the lichen began to heal. The pills certainly did not harm my friend.

Klug

INSPECTION!

In Kenedy on the weekend
the lazy hands stirred,
with broom, mop and other things,
to make the barracks clean.
An inspection then came by,
to check if it was really clean.
And often it was made clear to us,
that the room was still dirty.
It won't work with cold water,
the boards were supposed to be of quality.
We would have to scrub them mirror-like.
We were told how this could succeed:
Only using soap powder we would get the floor clean.
We did so, but the inspection?
It came, saw it and said:
Even today it is not clean here!
The next time we will lock you up!
Saturday came, but this time
we really didn't care about anything.
We flooded the place,
for then the floor remained wetter.
And soon after came the inspection.
They hardly saw us, when they already yelled:
What's the matter, what's going on?
Why is it so clean here?
And one of us reports quickly:
That the boards are so clean today,
we owe to the quantity of water,
for that makes the floor stay wetter.
With soap the same becomes pale,
but unfortunately it dries right away.
The inspector orders thereupon:
Scrubbing with soap stops right now.
Hoeffler

HAPPY EASTER!

At Kenedy's Officer's Camp we had some German personnel who worked in the kitchen, in the washroom, on the paths, and at the sports field. For these activities our soldiers took their time, since the end of captivity was not yet in sight and they needed tools like hoes, shovels, rakes, scythes, and the like. At the end of the workday, these things had to be returned, as such dangerous instruments could not be left with POW's. The officers as well as our men had small gardens in front of the barracks and could have made good use of the above mentioned tools. So soon one tool, then another, remained behind. The American sergeant who was in charge of the items came up with the unheard-of idea to hand-out the tools only against a signature. Smiling, he may have rubbed his hands together when he

conceived the idea, for now there would be no more missing items.

A Private, who urgently needed a hoe and a shovel for the evening, scratched behind his ear when the slip was presented to him for his signature. The American grinned, and then our soldier also had the necessary enlightenment. With a vigorous flourish, he signed with the words: **"Fröhliche Oster!"** (meaning "Happy Easter"). Deeply satisfied and happy, the American nodded his "Okay - everything in finest order", and the soldier ran off.

Since a hoe and a shovel were missing in the evening, in the whole camp there was a search for a soldier named "Happy Easter". Neither the man nor the tools were found. The next evening the count of hoes and shovels was correct again. Whether the sergeant wondered why and how his brilliant idea did not work, I do not know.

Klug

TEXAS MINES

Always, when we tell each other,
what tormented us particularly there,
I think of Texas Mines,
which certainly deserve this praise.
Strongly seized by the heat,
everyone stretches out in the open,
but one comes up again quickly,
what has stung us there?
And one searches for the animal,
that has stung us here,
however, nothing can be discovered
and one lays oneself down again.
But only briefly one found rest,
when one wanted to hide
some hand under the head,
one notices new stings.
Attentively one looks around.
Does one find something now?
Once again no little animal shows itself,
one calms down reasonably well.
But the third time rage comes.
Where is the fiendish brood hiding,
that pinches and tweaks us?
No one lies on the ground anymore.
Everyone searches for the animal,
the sight was funny to me.
Until a third person finally calls:
Here I have the little rascal.
But, who was the villain?
Simply a Texas Mine!
Small and ugly in shape,

but with prickly violence.
And the moral? I don't know it!
But know, when something stings you,
it does not always have to be an animal,
and think of this example here.

Kirchner

A MORNING, A NOON, AN EVENING AT KENEDY

You lie on your mattress with a clear conscience,
press your head deep into the pillows,
left or right, as it suits everyone,
but one cannot think as stupidly as it happens.
Then someone takes a deep breath through the nose
and releases it with much noise
with the help of a brass. Sleep is over.
Boys, get out!
Now you go up, into the trousers,
grab your towel, shaving kit and soap box,
chase through the room, time is tight.
Let them wait, the beard still has to come off.
Into the shirt, the jacket from the hanger,
barely reaching the left wing.
So we get a new O.o.D. (Officer on Duty).
Well, better than 14 days arrest. - O.K.
Now we are registered, inspected, counted,
meanwhile everyone has chosen the path,
to get to the dining hall fast.
And every morning it happens promptly,
how they push, shove and barge,
go on at each other and mix in between.
Then we taste the cake, the sweet one, the yellow one,
we drink coffee, it is always the same.
And march afterwards without rest, without peace
back towards our barrack.
A moment later the whole lot
lies again peacefully slumbering on their mattress.
Now you wake up. The clock points to eleven.
A Solitaire is laid out, it is always the same.
The seven on the eight, the six on the seven,
damn, where did the King go?
Then the clock strikes shortly before twelve.
Now we go to eat. It is always the same.
We peel potatoes and eat the cabbage,
the stomach is full, the muscles remain concave.
And go afterwards without rest, without peace
back towards our barrack.

A moment later the whole lot
lies again peacefully slumbering on the mattress.
At one you get up, the canteen is open.
Cigarettes bought, Dr. Pepper swigged.
Now you feel lousy. It bubbles inside you,
You go to the door, on which stands "Here".
But, woe, if there is something new,
then the queues stand, then the crowd is sieved.
If you are not on the alert and if it doesn't work out there,
the A-Street will snatch everything away.
With a sack full of clothes, without rest, without peace,
they move towards their barracks.
At three, we hear the situation report
We stand there with intelligent faces
and listen and prick up our ears:
Damn, damn, the war is lost!
The hope for victory has completely melted away,
the enemy has won a meter of terrain!
Then, quickly, the cards are consulted again,
they have always told us the truth.
The Solitaire doesn't work out, no nine came,
now one can only look forward to dinner.
Then there is gorging, panting, laughing,
if someone announces something, noise is made.
We peel the eggs, eat only the yolk,
and devour salad, it is always the same.
And go afterwards without rest, without peace
back towards our barrack.
In the evening there is a film, one watches it:
"One Million B.C." - "Uwe, my man."
You smirk amused in your corner,
Cigar in the mouth, a blanket under your buttocks,
and go afterwards without rest, without peace
back towards your barrack.
The evening is long, the hours still many.
You dither between free time and sense of duty.
Sense of duty wins, the wish swept away
and again a Solitaire is laid out.
Then someone takes a deep breath through the nose again
and releases it with much noise,
with the help of a brass. - The day is over,
the work, the worry, the drudgery.
The light goes out and the whole lot
lies again peacefully slumbering on their mattresses.
The Sandman gives wings to the worst shrews.
Oh, if only they were all angels.

Recited by the poet Hans Buse in Berlin in dialect within the scope of the entertainment evening on December 31, 1944.

MIDDAY REST

I already told that we lived in 2-man barracks. The little wooden houses had only thin walls, eleven windows and stood so close to each other that one could hear every loud word, yes even the snoring in a wide radius. It is clear that under such conditions the tones of Lieutenant Kehrer's trumpet and the squeaking clarinet sounds of our dear Limbach could be heard far and wide and gave occasion for adulations.

Limbach therefore usually went to the sports field, sat in the grass, placed the sheet music in front of him and let himself be disturbed by no one and nothing in his tireless zeal. This picture of touching assiduousness earned our Limbach the title of a "Snake Charmer". But I didn't actually want to tell about that. We ate lunch daily at half past eleven. From twelve to three o'clock was midday rest even for the most diligent, for the others until five. These three hours were scrupulously observed. The camp was as if extinct at this time. Woe to him who found the courage to disturb this holy silence. A flood of curse words rained down on him.

Near my friend Buschinger from Aschaffenburg lived a gentleman who had borrowed a hammer over midday to knock some nails into a chair being built. Everything was quiet around him, some gentlemen were already snoring, when he lifted the hammer with malicious intent. Powerfully he let it whiz down, he had hit well. But even before one of the neighboring officers had grasped that someone was violating the holy silence, he himself roared with all his physical strength: "Quiet! Midday rest." Everything remained quiet, for each of the neighbors thought, well, someone is already getting upset there, why should I bother? The second blow followed. The man called out in deep indignation: "Heavens, quiet! What kind of guy is that?" It remained silent. He risked the third nail and hardly had it was in place, he scolded furiously: "Such an impudent cheek, a bottomless meanness, to disturb the midday rest." A few more "flattering words" followed. Deeply contrite over his own lecture, the next blows rained down on the innocent nails, accompanied more and more by a flood of curse words that would have given a court of honor material for negotiation for weeks. The neighbors, long since shoed from sleep, smirked: There was finally someone who knew how to command respect, who placed no limits on his opinion, a splendid fellow.

My friend Buschinger, who had observed the frivolous game, smiled mischievously and came to us in the "Philosopher's Quarter" to tell us about it. We rejoiced at the resourceful mind who, despite the midday rest, had brought the necessary nails into the wood.

Klug

AT THE BARBER

Ever since we left England we had had no opportunity to have our hair cut. In Kenedy there was indeed a barrack that boasted the sign - Barber Shop - however, it harbored no human being who understood the art of hair cutting. A jester had

attached a poster with the inscription - Closed due to conscription - However, it had been removed again. From day to day we were put off by our "ruler" Martin, however, the hair did not let itself be disturbed in its growth by these hints, but grew and grew. Should we wear long hair like the old Germanic tribes? Some brave ones among us attempted the art of cutting on even braver victims, and since by unanimous agreement we had forbidden any female visitors, a few miscuts on the back of the head could not bother us, especially since we didn't see them. Some, like the two master brewers Ries and Braeuchle from Swabia, had their skulls shaved completely bald - a matter of taste! And with this sun radiation! Still others believed the promises and hoped a real hairdresser would take pity on their noble heads.

One day, one of us walked past the barber shop – with no intentions at all. He looked through the wire mesh that we had on all windows because of the fly plague. The room was still empty. He smiled, entered the room, and sat down waiting on one of the benches. He did not remain alone for long; soon a second one peeked through the wire mesh, saw the officer sitting patiently, sensed a splendid opportunity, and entered. A third, fourth, fifth gentleman came; Majors, Captains, and Lieutenants of both grades soon filled the room. When the first man saw the room so beautifully filled, he stood up and walked away. Quickly the vacated seat was occupied. Patiently the crowd waited for two hours; the hair certainly grew another piece in this peaceful silence. After this endless time, the officer who had gone away returned and gave his waiting comrades the comforting information: "Gentlemen, as I just learned from an decision maker, the barber is not coming today." With that, he was gone. There were long faces, some wanted to scold, but the sensible ones noticed what was going on, and so the assembly dissolved with laughter - the hair grew on!

Klug

EVERYTHING IS ROLLING

The first days were bad,
everyone went to the Adjutant:
Where is the money? I would like to write!
I want a piano to pass the time.
When will the supply room open?
When do the sports activities start?
Why is no cinema here?
Why no beer? I ask you please!
When can I finally change my socks?
I want to buy myself a pair of shoes.
I very urgently need my pictures.
The questions are becoming wilder.
How so? Why? Wherefore and what?
The Adjutant is already turning pale.
The answer, gentlemen, is:
The things are all on their way.
The school wants to be opened!

I need carving knives, very small!
Where are the colors for the painting?
The questions are not running out.
There even was a man,
who wanted a woman as a husband!
What to do? I do what I can:
The things are all rolling on!

Kirchner

THE UNKNOWN RUNNER

After a hot day he repeatedly walks past the bench we are sitting on in the cooling evening hour. Slowly he strides along, hands laid on his back, gaze directed in front of him on the ground. He seems to have forgotten everything around him. Serious, profound, and introverted, he walks one lap after another. With always the same, serious concentration he pursues his thoughts. What might he be thinking? Is a decision maturing in him or is he seeking the solution to a world riddle? Actually, we want to call out a greeting to him, but we refrain, because the depth of his thoughts is sacred to us. There he comes again, is it the ninth or even the tenth time? Suddenly he stoops briefly and, quickly, picks something up from the path. A triumphant radiance goes over his face. Discovering us, he comes towards us and says, rejoicing in his voice: "I just found it - the thirtieth nail!"

R. Koenig

THE SWAPPED HAIR TONIC

Who does not know him, Artur Benz, who was awarded the Philosopher's Stone because he dedicated himself to all sciences that were taught in Kenedy. Mostly he sits in his corner and hammers into the musician's skull whatever will go in. But suddenly he jumps up, conjures with mighty gestures and terrifying vocal input all evil spirits onto the heads of the noisemakers and sneerers. In doing so, he lets - not entirely without intent - his black thick hair fall into his face, only to throw it back onto his neck with a violent, skillful movement. Yes, he has a special weakness for his shock of hair, he who is at home in the world of spirits and places little value on outward appearances. And the comrades of Barrack H 7 also know of this weakness.

In order to be able to grant his hair the most careful care, he tries out all hair tonics and finally finds what he is looking for in a dark brown colored one. With it, he works on his shock of hair every evening, full of fervor and to everyone's joy, and finally he arranges it into a bold hairstyle. But not only the hair, also the scalp is the object of his attention. It must be kept cool and fresh so that the spirit remains alive and the memory receptive.

Then a delicious idea comes to one of his barrack comrades, just as he is drinking his tea. He takes a cup of tea to the room and compares the color with that of the hair tonic. Both have the same hue. The fragrant tonic is squirted away and replaced by the same amount of tea. Everyone is let in on the secret. With tension and tingling anticipation, all look forward to the evening massage. Suspecting nothing, the good Benz trickles the tea into his hair and begins to scrub and knead

his scalp. After a while he stops to observe the effect, shakes his head slightly disapprovingly and distressed, and then pours plenty of water onto his hair. The twenty-three room comrades can hardly contain themselves from laughing. Only he, who is the cause of the general hilarity, makes a sour face and suspects nothing.

The priceless game repeats itself on the four following days. The joy rises to a new height when someone tells him, deadly serious, that the hair tonic must be good, his hair has taken on such a soft warm shine as never before. And there Artur Benz recommends, confirming the quality, of the tonic, of which he alone does not know that it is tea.

At a wedding celebration – marriage by proxy - the secret is finally revealed. Everyone had expected that Artur's temperament would run away with him and he would make a murderously huge row. But the effect is a completely different one. After he has quickly recovered from his astonishment, a sigh wrests itself from his chest, a smile goes like an enlightenment over his face. Redeemed from a suffering borne manfully and quietly, he exclaims: "Thank God, I already thought my scalp nerves were sick. For a few days the hair tonic did not cool anymore, as usual, but warmed." Then everyone in the round laughed heartily and with them this time also - Artur Benz -.

Koenig

IN THE BEYOND

Fate has now overtaken me;
the captain aimed exactly
and found my secret stock,
which I had laid out as a precaution
for hunger-strike hours
and hidden under the barrack.
Oberwegner's evil face
threatened me for the story
with nine months of real prison,
Sueßmann looks at me maliciously.
It then turns out, oh fright, oh horror,
to be still "fourteen days".
Beyond the fence stands the house.
I am even allowed out the gate.
But unfortunately it goes right back in
to long, heavy dungeon pain.
So that I don't sweat in the night,
I am even stripped naked.
The cell is small, the iron thick,
the back is buckled, the neck stiff.
Three steps back, three steps fro,
to walk oneself tired is terribly difficult.
The metal bunk gives me cold buttocks.
I would not like to stay overwinter here .
However, I am not alone for long,

for soon reinforcements come in.
The beautiful rooms fill up,
the comrades comfort me.
We seek our entertainment
in appropriate interior design.
The bread tastes good, the water bad.
We look through the wire mesh,
whether there is a racket on the sports field,
try this and that trick,
to chase away the boredom,
which is gradually becoming unbearable.
Then finally the time is over,
the Sergeant roars: Let's go, okay.
I can march through the gate again,
just in time to take photographs.
The baggy trousers show clearly,
that I was over there in the Beyond.

Koenig

UNIQUE SENSATION !!

FOOTBALL KICK-OFF BY A BEAUTIFUL WOMAN !!

TODAY KENEDY SPORTS FIELD 3:00 PM

Next to the things that we love,
much sport was also practiced.
To liven up the whole thing
there had to be sensations.
Therefore, when the field was opened,
immediately there was the right start.
In advance it was announced to us,
that, before the game took place,
a beautiful looking woman
would be on the spot
and kick the brand new ball
today for the first time.
For a long time we haven't seen
girls with a beautiful face.
Soon we had to forget
such charming figures,
since the fence of barbed wire
has locked the world away from us.
So we hurried at the right hour
to the field's large round,
where in front of each of their goals
the football corps already stood,
to await the kick-off,
which this girl was supposed to start.

Finally they approached.
The girl had linked arms
in a tall youth's arm.
Behind them followed a swarm
of young civilians,
with straw hats and a bow tie on.
The girl had taken my fancy,
so I went quite close,
to look at her facial features.
They were truly beautiful,
and I was already rejoicing
at the good proportion.
She had freshly applied rouge,
the fingernails very manicured,
and powder in thick layers.
The eyes were of such splendor,
that my heart laughed joyfully.
The legs were well built,
probably everyone looked at them.
A short, bright summer dress
showed the body's stateliness,
while the waved hair
was covered by a little hat.
I saw her go onto the sports field,
play around a little at the ball.
Then she daintily pushed it with her sandal.
This was the kick-off then,
and the game really began.
Still quite inspired by such a sight
I went back into my barrack.
The more I thought and wondered
an idea came up in me:
This face, you know it after all!
As every Prisoner's face
passed before my inner eye,
it was suddenly completely clear to me,
that it was only a disguise,
and the girl was only a POW!

Hoefffer

THE FIRST SCHOOL DAY

The first days in Kenedy, all conversations revolved around the battles in France and the capture. The endless variations slowly became too much for me and I decided to bring other topics up for discussion. With my modest scientific knowledge, I organized evening lectures and had the joy of seeing how other gentlemen joined in, and the topics of conversation took non-warlike paths.

The lectures turned into lecture series, and it turned out that we had high school teachers of all disciplines and could open a high school. There was also no lack of officers who were interested in obtaining the High School Diploma (Abitur). So one day the request was made to me to call an Abitur course into life and to head it. Call into life, yes; to be the headmaster, no. The other teachers agreed with my suggestions and at my request, Comrade Grosskinsky from Constance took over as Head of the School. I had made a good choice with him, for Grosskinsky led the course exemplary, overcame many difficulties, in short, was much more suitable for the post than I. I took over physics, biology, and part of mathematics. Over fifty officers had registered as students. I was supposed to start with physics. When, early on Monday, I entered the chapel, which was intended as a classroom, a colorful picture presented itself to me. All officers who were registered as students came accompanied by their "parents." They had school satchels on their backs, large bags full of "sweets" in one hand, the other convulsively held that of the "father," all were intimidated, as only first graders can be. I had to urge the fathers to return home so that I could begin with the lesson. A tumult arose. "Be fine, good and well-behaved, my darling." - "If you have to go out, report it, the teacher will let you out then." - "Don't shame me." - "Pay good attention so that you learn something." - "Don't cry, my heart, it won't last long, then you'll come home again." - "Do I really have to stay here?" - "I don't like it here at all." - "Papa, you can go home quietly, I won't stay here anyway." - "Why didn't I take my toy train with me?" As an old teacher, I grasped the situation and went from student to student to win them over to stay with kind words. I succeeded and "fathers" could leave their hopeful offspring. I told them in farewell they could pick up their "boys" again at twelve o'clock. Finally, the lesson began. Unfortunately, no one had wanted to go out. I regretted it deep in my heart. In all quiet, I could speak with my "boys" about the concept and the definition, to get to the basic physical concepts. However, I allowed them the lollipop, which they strangely lit with a match. The beautiful game from the morning was unfortunately over - but my "boys" were indeed picked up by their "fathers." The next day the boys came to school alone and I took much joy in teaching them.

Klug

PETER SCHNURR THE RIPPER

WANTED POSTER - REWARD 100 ACTIVE! (Vigarettes?)!

How did it come to the story,
of which is reported with horror,
that our brave tomcat Schnurr
is called the "gray murderer".
Every day in glaring sun,
he waits for the delight of food;
he eats it peacefully, with deliberation,
so that "Cat Paul's" heart laughs in joy.
"You are indeed the most magnificent,
the mightiest of all cats.
Let your belly bulge quietly -

the sneerer will feel your claws!"
How Peter Schnurr understands the praise!
Purring, he winds around Paul's legs,
eats happily bacon, chop and sausage
and sips comfortably milk against his thirst.
There, one morning it happened,
"Little Foot" is seen as a corpse.
Murdered by evil forces.
A commission is quickly ordered.
It determined, oh woe, oh horror,
that Little Foot looks deteriorated.
And the smell, since she is decaying,
is fought immediately with "After Shave".
With threatening, distorted expression,
for such a crime demands atonement -
stand Lukas, Krausch and also Klein.
Who can be the murderer here?
There Schnurr sneaks along the barbed wire.
A look, a jump, one hardly sees him.
The sharp eye of the court
has seen him - A light flashes!
"There the evil murderer goes home!
Get up, let us be Little Foot's avengers."
But only after thorough trial
did the murder's strict punishment happen.
In the dining hall one sees flaunting
the call for action against the scoundrel,
for it was Peter Schnurr alone,
is now the view of the Little-Foot-Crowd.
Paul Mueller with the Schnurr-comrades
was very annoyed by the suspicion.
He looks quite darkly with his people
to those who think otherwise.
The next day it flashes anew
and springs into everyone's face,
that only Schnurr is the murderer.
Catch him now with all the cunning!
Thus the commission has found.
Are the murderer's hours now numbered?
Will he end by henchman's hand?
Or can the page be turned?
The Schnurr-supporters then decided
and announced it and made it known,
that a lawyer had been chosen,
who places the motion on "Reason".
An examination was ordered,

to find who murdered the cat.
Quite loudly one argued for and against
and in the end knocked down the verdict.
Peter Schnurr, innocent and honest,
stands in old prestige again.
And the moral of the story:
A tomcat does not kill the female cat!

Kaufmann

THE FOUR VILLAGE MUSICIANS

After we had received so many beautiful things in Kenedy, like a movie palace, canteen, stadium, and a large casino with piano and radio, we also wanted to have some real music. And one fine day, a lot of large and small crates were dragged into the barrack of our Chief Musician Kaestner, from which musical instruments of all types and sizes came out. That the instruments were tried out after lunch during the holy midday rest and that thereby the inhabitants of the entire North-East Quarter of the camp worked on the Kaestner barrack with stones, clubs, and water buckets until unconditional surrender, shall only be mentioned in passing. At the beginning of the year 1945, four figures appeared one evening shortly before taps in the camp streets. These were the four village musicians: Kerer with the trumpet, then two silver-shining clarinets with the associated players, Limbach and Leo Puetz, and the Saxophone-Koenig, to distinguish him from Book-Koenig. They positioned themselves on the large concrete slab on A-Street and started to blow. But, what was that? The "Rosmarienheide", which had sounded so beautiful during rehearsals, was a mess of terrible dissonances. They stopped, consulted, and started from the beginning. Again the same. Now it was time to change position, for the surrounding barracks opened their doors and the inmates streamed out to look at the noise-makers. Under the lantern at the "Thingplatz" (assembly square), a new attempt was made. The "Rosmarienheide" could not be persuaded, it did not want to go. Now the culprit was sought. Who played wrong? That can only be the Saxophone-Koenig, because he is still a bloody beginner on his big instrument. But no, he knew exactly that it wasn't him. So there was nothing left but to hold another rehearsal down in the large classroom. There it turned out that the good Kerer had used the notes for his private use, where the "Rosmarienheide" stood in **F-Major**, while it was written for the quartet in **G-Major** and was played like that by the others. No wonder that the musicians were always merrily received after this premiere, just as little as that someone often called after them: "Leo, do 'toot'", because the treacherous clarinet had a few times given off a loud "toot" instead of the desired high C.

At almost every appearance the Four brought new melodies. When even the noble yodeler Schatz joined in and accompanied "From Lucerne to Weggis" (Swiss folk song), there was a big cheer, especially in the Forest- and Misery-Quarters down below.

Thus the musicians became an indispensable part of camp life and soon belonged, especially on birthdays - nearly every day one was celebrated - to the Kenedy evening events, like the bacon and eggs to the supper.

Koenig

H. 9.

Quite wrongly one called here,
the quarters "Misery Quarters",
where the Lieutenants did dwell,
well separated from other groups.
At H 7 and H 9,
in the small O-Barracks (Officer Barracks).
It was a colorful pack,
even if many a person did not rejoice.
To please everyone,
is an art that no one can do.
To be happy takes little,
this saying made us blissful,
was the motto of H 9.
It could not be otherwise.
For the old Lieutenants were,
even if mostly young in years,
punished hard by fate.
Nevertheless, they had the strength,
to strive for all the good in life.
With humor and much understanding
we soon made ourselves known.
Everyone spoke: "Oh, how fine,
becomes the room of H 9.
Look, the curtains here
are only made of toilet paper.
And the stove of cardboard."
Finally, a thought indeed
to pass time for once,
and the memory, it will remain.
Hardly did the room's splendor stand,
new work is being done.
A casino must now be here,
that is not hard for us at all.
And soon there was a huge activity,
everyone liked that very much.
-Oh, mes dames, faites votre jeu!
Everyone played, un petit peu
-Rien ne va plus - now comes the - huit -
no one bet? Then we are even.
And while the game went on,
thoughts grasped a new goal.
We build an omnibus,
so that everyone has to laugh for once.

The large table is just right,
The stool seat as a wheel not bad.
Cardboard as side walls - no -
who can be so inventive.
The radiator and the steering wheel,
and finished is the apparatus.
"The Meat and Beans - Texas - Express." -
I would feel sorry for anyone who forgot that,
the evening with the test drive,
the camp was gathered around
and roared, laughed and screamed:
how splendid, funny, fine that is.
Even the American heard it
and hurried as fast as possible to see.
Oh shock, a car, please help,
Otherwise the Germans are driving off.

DRAGON

Not long, a new prank inflamed,
boredom was damned.
On Tuesday morning we were supposed to scrub,
the American will also look surprised.
But some of the comrades
were too anxious; perhaps it would do harm,
they washed the floor clean after all
and already the hanky panky began.
The Captain approaches: "What is the name?"
This is naturally very convenient.
"Come on, lets go, for fourteen days."
Otherwise I'll get so angry again.
On a beautiful afternoon,
the clock was not yet very late,
one saw H 9 step into the open.
But they certainly didn't want to pray.
A kite had caught their fancy,
now it climbed cheerfully heavenward.
But not to Oberwegner's joy,
the poor guy, we felt sorry for him.
A new prohibition he now ordered,
perhaps there will finally be peace.

The Midday Rest on H 9,
was always observed punctually.
Even if some vile creature
wanted to disturb us, hear the story!
Table tennis was played on Sunday,

for some perhaps a relief.
But our nerves ran away,
away with the rackets, never mind.
From 3 o'clock you can play again,
But now bow to our will.
Also many a beneficial lesson
we imparted. "Despite the reverence"
for ranks higher than ours.
Many thanked us for it!
I think of the barrel jumpers;
we pointed the finger at them.
And think of the naked foot;
like that food was no pleasure
and of the man in underpants.
It was enough to make us cry now and then!
This was for us the meaning of life.
Even if it was often in vain.
I think there of the misery
for example with the Montgolfiere (Hot Air Balloon).
But the balance was positive,
which pleased us completely.
We gladly basked in the brilliance
of so many a wreath awarded to us
after every dance for our great elegance.
Kirchner

OUR FILM PALACE

Where are all the many people going
with blankets, chairs, benches?
To the cinema! For we'll see today
a new film passing by.
Up there, on the large assembly square,
the "Thingplatz", well known to all,
there shines like a white flag
a gigantic wooden board wall.
Well wrapped in coats, blankets,
under the starlit sky,
gathers from all corners
the cheerful crowd of guests.
First someone tells us what is offered,
what is the name of the film? how does it end?
is there a fight? The number of dead
determines the audience's applause.
Now it begins and Charley's Aunt
creates confusion with humor;
did you see how Boley ran with the ball?

What is going on in the ghost house?
Popeye has eaten three pounds of spinach,
at the "Holiday-Inn" there is a lot going on,
the "Big Number" we will never forget,
where are the "Flowers from Nice"?
Some like it, the others feel lousy.
One goes home when it becomes too much,
or when Saint Peter lets it rain,
and lays down quickly on his mattress.
Meanwhile the film is over,
some part with cries of mockery,
some grumble and laugh, claim to know better,
and soon after press their head onto the pillows.
Koenig

THE MUTE PIANO

Finally, their wish has come true. A house of their own has been assigned to the four friends. After a good week, I enter their little house with tense anticipation. Under the direction of the architect, Otto Jaeger, a cozy, tasteful interior will have emerged. But my disappointment is great. The living room differs in no way from the rooms of other POW bachelors. A colorful mess of art, science, and POW everyday life on the wall shelves. Dim light high on the ceiling, hardly a picture on the wall, no flowers on the table, on which a sleeping blanket lies. That and the corner bench are the only objects making an impression. They were left behind by the previous owners. Also, the relationship of the four to each other seems unclear. I feel obliged to cheer them up a little. I describe to them a vision created for this purpose. "How can I be," I begin, "a guest at your place. I hardly recognize the room as yours." It really is. On wall shelves and racks lie and stand books, notebooks, and sheet music, well arranged. In vain I look for bottles, washing utensils, cardboard boxes, and cleaning equipment. The drawings, neatly framed, originate from Otto Jaeger. On the work tables lie flower covers, flowers stand on them. We all sit harmoniously under the lamp - crafted by Klaus Meindl - around the table. Heinrich Erk reads us Hoelderlin's "Archipelagus" and" I falter, as the 'vision' loses its power. "And" Artur Benz unexpectedly picks up the lost thread, "I open the lid of my square piano" - he thereby puts the table cloth back on his side of the table. My eyes overflow and do not want to believe what they see - a complete keyboard with black and white keys, "and play" Benz continues, "the Sonata Pathétique by Beethoven." His hands glide over the keys, grip and play so genuinely that I believe I hear what cannot be audible, since the "piano" lacks chords. Finally, I have recovered from the surprise and fathom his secret. A board onto which keys made of cardboard and paper are glued. The whole thing is nailed under the table. That is all. Artur Benz built it for himself, to be able to play at any time undisturbed and without disturbing. On this instrument, Otto Jaeger must strike the "A" and hum every time the signal is blown for meals. With a tuning fork, Artur then determines whether the "piano" is not out of tune. That goes well at first - until the matter becomes too stupid for the good-natured Jaeger. Indeed, he still strikes the "A", but bleats an unambiguous

"Baaah" into the ears of the musician, rigid in horror.

When we move to Dermott, Artur stows his "piano" in his duffel bag. It passes the baggage check. In the new camp, however, there is a lack of space and wood. So it sinks down to a storage shelf for cosmetic articles. Whether shoes were built from it later? It was at least intended.

Koenig

HIGH VISIT

I know exactly, it was a Sunday.
when we read on a notice:
High visit is coming here today!
Therefore we cleaned very much everywhere,
where dirt lay, so that it would be clean,
because a Lady came by,
from the philanthropic society.
Was it pity for the POW? No!
The lady was only interested.
In what? Pitiable, the poor one.
But, it turned out differently than thought,
for as she makes a round,
she inquires touchingly and lovely,
whether the POW's were doing nice.
Whether the barbed wire was cruel?
Affirmed, she noted this down.
"I can you help, I know exactly,
even if I am a weak woman.
Watch out, it won't take much longer,
then you will be in freedom again."
What is the name? Can you me say?
O, Mister Kalb, very okay!
The name is good! I know indeed.
The listeners laughed like crazy.
A teasing and dear word,
she continuously sighed softly:
"I help you, gentleman! Believe me."
And then above all: "take it easy!"
Which we were also ready for,
for this woman, she was clever.
The large entertainment room
could hardly hold the audience.
Everyone pushed towards the lady,
untill she made everyone ready.
Here she inspected closely,
for she was indeed a woman,
provided still with all charms,
that inspire men's hearts.

Yes, many a one said to himself:
"Damn it again, a pretty child."
"O, Mister Fuerst, how do you do?
A story will be now about you!"
Mr. Fuerst, he laughs and kisses
the hands of the beautiful child.
"You run the shop here very good,
you are also a big shot."
And then she said enraptured:
"You have quite often run already."
We all laughed madly and cheerfully.
"You continue running, man."
"And you, you are Major ai Aschi (i.G) (General Staff)
Something like that I have never heard before.
Will see my book, what is about."
She greeted him quite loudly.
"O yes, I found, Peter's Major,
in General Staff you occur.
You live in the Lime Kiln;
the beautiful tents are over.
Good bye, my dear, I must go."
About which Peters was very glad.
How are you and how do you do?
She called to so many others
and everyone's heart beat quite often
with joy over this joke.
When she finally left us,
we could really hardly grasp it;
but one knew it exactly,
the lady was no woman at all!
Once again we swiftly laughed
from longing for the beautiful child.

Kirchner

THE ZOO

Every big city has its zoo,
in Kenedy it was just the same;
one could envy this city.
The beginning was indeed very modest:
In the first warm weeks
a turtle came crawling
through the fence of barbed wire,
which surrounds the camp.
Heinz Klein fetches it for himself,
he set up an enclosure.
She went walking with him quite proudly,

without getting lost at all.

If someone displeased her critical gaze,
she withdrew into her shell.

The trick was generally acknowledged,
therefore she was named Diogenes.

When even more little animals arrived,
a garden was started,

with swimming pools, caves and rocky reefs,
castor oil plants, cactus and other gimmicks,
and decorated all around with flower beds.

Inside they were accommodated, the turtles, geckos
and the little ants with their deftly legs.

For the visitors from the big world
a bench was placed in front,
so that they could easily and without effort
observe the menagerie.

Koenig

OF SCORPIONS, SPIDERS, ANTS AND OTHER CRITTERS

Paul and I were relishing the twilight hour. The sun had sunk. Night came striding from the sea faster than in Germany. We talked of home. In a corner of the room stood two tin cans in which we fetched water for the flowers. A bright tinny sound interrupted the quiet of the room. I turned on the light and saw a scorpion that had fallen from the smooth ceiling into one of the tin cans. It could just as well have fallen into my bed. We killed it. The next day we plugged all cracks in the floor with roofing felt and never had a scorpion in the room again. Our neighbor Willi had more bad luck; he touched such a fellow unseen while making his bed. Both, Willi and the scorpion, were frightened. The animal had stung immediately. Willi screamed, killed the attacker and ran to the infirmary to have the sting treated. If one walked around the camp in the evening, one could see a lot of these animals approaching the barracks, attracted by the glaring light of the spotlights. Many had to lose their lives.

Another nasty room-mate was a spider, called Black Widow. Its bite was dangerous. Paul and other POW's kept widows in jars and fed them. My room mate had fed his spider as fat as the tomcat Schnurr. Braeuchle had once placed a number of ants before his animal - it happened as I had suspected: The spider's limbs were bitten off. With that I come to these dear little animals, about whose life and intelligence I once gave a lecture. We had various species of ants in the camp. All loved sugar. Their processions on self-built roads were often observed. In the room, they could admittedly become unpleasant. Known to all are the ring-shaped mounds around the entrance holes.

In the grass, green praying mantises were often found, wicked robbers, whose females, like some spiders, eat their males after mating out of "love". Nothing can be done about that! Walking sticks, looking like walking straws, also moved between dry grasses. Magnificent camouflage!

A lot of beetle species crawled and scurried around the barracks, some with

glowing colors on the shell. Once a married couple of dung beetles came rolling to our barrack with a dung ball, - the female sat lazily on the vehicle and let herself be driven. The cradle for the larvae was buried in our garden. Paul and I had almost missed the evening roll call in contemplation of things.

Long thick millipedes pattered across the path or lay spirally coiled in the sand. Butterflies scuttled in large numbers from flower to flower, sometimes magnificently large and colorful pieces among them. Even many grasshoppers showed colorful wings in flight. Large migratory locusts and crickets were caught and consumed by the tomcat Schnurr. We perceived almost nothing of fever mosquitoes; every water puddle was strictly forbidden as a development site for these animals.

Horned frogs and turtles were gladly kept, of which Diogenes, living in a barrel, was the most famous representative. Often Klein or Krausch, both great animal lovers, went walking with him and it was cute when the turtle walked voluntarily like a little dog next to his master. And if Diogenes ever deviated from the path, he went at most to the barbed wire, then he turned back.

I saw snakes only twice, both non-venomous, one was slain, the other shot by a guard.

To the long-handled flowers came hummingbirds, which were gladly observed when they hovered whirring before the blossoms and sucked nectar. A type of thrush sang to us its beautiful flute songs for weeks and answered when we whistled. Large shrikes impaled migratory locusts and crickets on our barbed wire and everywhere one saw dead animals hanging. Birds of paradise boasted with their beautiful colors and long tails. Vultures drew their wide circles in gliding flight. Wild geese flew in V-formation high in the air to the sea and often I thought: Oh, if I only could travel with them!

Klug

... AND SOMETHING OF THE FLORA

On the stretch from Houston to Kenedy we saw arid steppe grasses and at the few wooden cottages palms and man-high cacti, Opuntias. The climate of this area could be put in two words: hot and dry. And so it was. For weeks the sun burned day after day from an almost cloudless sky, a sultry south wind blew from the Gulf of Mexico over the plateau of Texas and not a drop of rain fell. The ground was hard as cement and when it did rain, it poured in streams. The water flowed off rapidly, as the hard ground could not absorb it. In such an area only plants can grow that can deal extremely economically with water, or that find the groundwater table with their main root, or that bloom quickly and wilt again.

The character of the landscape was determined, as already mentioned, by steppe grasses and only here and there a tree towered out of the desolate monotony, not high and with small leaves evaporating little water, probably Acacia species. Of the grasses, a sedge with its prickly fruits, which attached themselves everywhere and stung badly when touched by hand and foot, gave us much trouble. We called them Texas Mines. The grass picture was interrupted by a few flowers, like primroses, some papilionaceous flowers and thistles. In the camp itself, flowers only grew when watered daily. As trees, we found some pines with silky-soft needles, then the Acacia and those that bore glass-hard leaves, so hard that one could use them for

sanding wood.

At some barracks Oleander grew and bloomed. Its branches greeted those celebrating birthdays. Paul and I used its leaves to bind our Advent wreath. Next to this bush, the Thuja occidentalis placed its leaves perpendicular to the ground. If a POW wanted to have only little work with his garden, then he grew two or three Castor bean plants, which grew very rapidly; in a few weeks they became meters high, and then looked great with their large leaves. Preferably the sensitive plant, Mimosa pudica, was grown, whose leaves folded together at every touch and closed towards the middle, an adaptation to the tropical rain, which would tear off the tender leaves. Sunflowers did not need to be planted, they grew by themselves everywhere if one did not pull them out. On the street and at the infirmary stood Yucca palms, which bloomed magnificently and beautiful. The flower heads reached probably twice the height of the plant and carried many white little bells in grape form.

The cacti also bloomed magnificently. Unfortunately, the glory always lasted only hours. Next to the cacti stood the Aloes in beautiful specimens. At a barrack cotton grew next to its relative mallow. Iris, blooming white and yellow, provided birthday blossoms with a calla lily. At Christmas time, beautiful red roses smelled next to the infirmary. Unfortunately, we always missed a dear woman to whom we could have given them. It was even possible for my friend Paul to pick a real Loofah and make himself the original Loofah sponge out of it.

At the cinema square, under the direction of little Lohmann, a flower park was laid out, which gave us much joy. At our wash barrack, Mathiszik cared tirelessly for his darlings, the flowers.

Klug

THE SCHNAPS DISTILLERY

Some people cannot let it be,
indulging everywhere in the "wet stuff" [booze].

Among us were also people,
who were not at all pleased,
that one should live without the juice of the vines,
without schnaps and beer.

For the thirst from earlier times
had to suffer terribly now.

It soon became known from one man,
the name shall not be mentioned here,
that despite higher powers
he understood how to stick to schnaps.

He collected the peels from fruit,
which he then hid in a water pot,
so that no human being
would discover the fermentation process.

After a few weeks it was time,
and in great festivity
the noble liquid was tasted.

Probably no one was shy there,
to heartily drink the schnaps.
And since one loved such carousing,
so even during this fun
the courage for new fermenting was seized.
But at the next inspection
there already was the drama:
The pot with schnapps, very well hidden,
was discovered by the Americans after all.
The schnaps host was quickly found,
and was then told bluntly,
should that happen once again,
they would lock him up for sure!
But the host absolutely didn't care.
Without limits was his thirst.
He puts the schnaps in the Chapel
and considered it a safe spot.
The Americans, however, came there
and also found the schnaps at this place.
His punishment followed immediately;
the host moved into his prison.
When he was then released,
it was immediately clear to him,
that in his own distillery
a new schnaps had to be made.
And with outsized delight
he puts the liquid into a barrel,
which in case of fire
was filled with oily water.
During the third search operation
the host just barely got away,
because they pulled the noble liquid
also out of that barrel.
And only for lack of evidence
they did not put him into prison,
but every schnaps host was threatened
with long imprisonment on dry bread.
So it would be completely clear,
that from now on there would be peace.
Only the schnaps host was tormented
by the thought that something is missing,
and brewed freshly with old strength
secretly a new poisonous juice.
Yes, some cannot be put off
and indulge everywhere in the "wet stuff".

Hoeffler

AROUND THE SPORTS FESTIVAL

What can be more beautiful in the world,
than a pleasure without spending money.
As we had it many a day,
when sun lay over Kenedy.
The sports field was then always open
and mostly one could also hope,
that something was going on there,
even if it was just a training game.
But slowly the interest slowed,
one hungered for other fun.
Then "compulsory sport" was introduced,
for lack of talent this had to be.
Now sport was practiced - far and wide -
one had indeed lots of time.
From early till late, old and young,
had all sorts of things to do.
But not enough, a Sports Festival came.
One should fight for the victory.
Also age classes one and two
were allowed to be there at the fight.
But beforehand it cost sweat,
because the days were so hot.
And work, it was heavy back then,
but an arena had to be built.
Indefatigably the valet pushed us,
it was no longer comfortable,
he drove us to work. My goodness!
As long until the arena was finished.
Finally the festival could begin,
one was allowed to fight for the laurels.
Sport is healthy - was the slogan.
Everyone did it for his well-being.
Three days the racing lasted,
only the will to win was known.
Whether clean and jerk, high jump or running,
all were contested without pauses.
Even the American Captain came,
to see what a POW can do.
The starting shot bangs, the pack ran.
I want to see though, who is first.
O, Yes, I know, this is the Fuerst,
who has now become first.
Okay, lets go, I have no time,
and as fast as possible he went home again.

On the third day, there came the highlight:
Lap run through the whole camp.
Everyone ran along with iron will,
although many suffered secretly.
For unmercifully shone the sun,
it was not every man's delight;
in addition the arena was miserably hot.
Who participated, knows that exactly.
There were now some quite clever ones:
One lap is not far at all.
The feet bare, wherefore the use of shoes.
Leave a sportsman in peace!
The run began, it was a joy
over the these people's speed.
The calls, screams were cheerful,
still the race went on.
In the end there was only one winner.
But many scolded themselves,
for not being much smarter.
Now it was too late.
To the Hospital everyone goes,
to treat the many wounds,
which they got from the running
with bare feet. Never again!
Even if duty urges so much.
The doctor now had more work
than was certainly dear to him.
Instead of feet he saw only shreds,
and everyone complained about pain.
Come here with Iodine and Tetanus!
To the devil again with the foot.
What have you made? I don't believe;
Everything went wrong today!
For many this was an honor,
who athletically still tapped in the void.
Sport is healthy - but note,
only as far it agrees with you.

Kirchner

FAREWELL TO KENEDY

Even for a POW there is no staying,
we felt that ourselves.
Why move again? Let's go home,
then the whole charade is over.
Rumors whizzed back and forth.
The uncertainty weighed heavily.

Where to? How far? What is the name of the city?
How many inhabitants does it have?
There was secret talk of a transit camp.
Repatriation was also a popular rumor.
And there was excitement, big and much,
because no one knew the new destination.
But despite the alarm for some days,
we had slept quite well
even without bedding. But for consolation:
we are indeed leaving tomorrow.
The last day, it still brought pain,
the houses had to be clean.
Out with table and chair and shrine.
Take along? What are you thinking?
So came the farewell from the wood,
of which we were so proud for many weeks,
because it beautified our life,
we had to return it to the Americans.
The next day, there was the time,
for our train stood already waiting.
To the train station we went with quick steps.
And every POW had to come along.

THE JOURNEY TO ARKANSAS

As now the train hurried
with windy speed through many miles,
we came further and further away
from the place that had become familiar,
then one felt for the first time,
what the camp had been to us.
Here one reads it, but it was more beautiful,
since we experienced it with body and soul.
It was uplifting.
Only when the "dear" kitchen wagon,
brought the food for the stomach,
there we saw at a glance:
The past was that which was behind.
Now comes the rough reality,
a large camp, not far at all,
shall be the new destination and home.
What were we thinking?
The train, however, made a sudden stop,
there was talk of a waterfall,
which had flooded everything
and had hindered our train.
There we sat for many hours,

bound to our train compartment.
Until the water level was down
and trains could drive again.
So it was later than planned,
that our train finally arrived.
We saw there many lights
greeting us as a happy destination.
Quite a few thought: Gosh,
this camp is significantly nicer.
It is indeed a small city,
that has only POW inhabitants.
Viewed at night it was beautiful;
But, oh woe, seen by day
quite a lot was no longer so good.
But we had become wise,
not to make such a racket anymore,
since it is all in vain!
But enough! Now hear what I wrote,
of our quiet operation!

Kirchner

THE VEGETABLE GARDEN

In the camp many places were free.
To us this was completely indifferent,
only not to Knehr, now Major,
and Council of Agriculture before that,
he looked daily at the many meadows:
"How vegetables could grow here after all
the soil is indeed flawless!
Why didn't I see it sooner?"
From now on we had to stir ourselves
and lay out a garden plot
with hoe, shovel and a spade.
Potatoes, cucumbers and tomatoes,
carrots, beans and even more
we planted in the Garden Knehr.
We were sick of the work soon,
but a voice sounds loud:
"The soil is of great fertility
and there exists the possibility,
that the food for us will be better,
when we have the harvest in."
Success was long in coming,
even if Knehr daily provided his garden
by help of highest science
with noble growth power.

Time passed, almost nothing thrived.
The company became quite grumpy.
Only Knehr had high confidence
and spoke to us: "Just do not despair,
it just takes a little more time.
But then exists - the possibility,
that here in my company
we will eat, like never before."
We no longer believed in the blessing,
rejoiced only in the rain,
for then we had nothing to do
and could rest on the bed.
And only Knehr, the brave man,
looked at his garden.
But otherwise much work was done
for the benefit of the noble agriculture.
But we never harvested,
for later the company had to
go into new accommodations,
and with the garden it was over.
After this magnificent poem
hear the moral of the story:
For a leader of a company
one should never take a farmer.
For then you must dig daily,
without having any benefit.

Hoefffer

ANOPHELES

Pests in numbers of millions
are in the Mississippi Valley.
In form of little Anopheles,
which tormented us quite terribly.
Since they stung me quite awful,
I want to report how it was.
It never left us any peace,
Anopheles, the flying beast.
One could no longer be calm,
for fear of the fly to come in.
And if it was finally in the house,
It was over with our sleep.
Maliciously it waited,
until everyone was asleep.
Then it plunged in steep flight
onto its poor victims.
When it had had enough,

it flew back into the room corner
and took a little nap itself,
to be fresh in the early morning
and to trouble us again.
Easier said than done.
We noticed that when we began
to search for antidotes
to book success for us.
First we made the fly nets tight,
so that it does not come to the light,
Then we wear no short trousers
or clothes from which legs protrude.
We never go naked to the washroom,
or do not stand with exposed body.
And many other things more,
which we had to keenly observe.
Only then, so speaks the brave man,
the fly can do nothing more to us.
Unfortunately we also knew little,
about the customs of the fly.
No wonder that a teacher came
and started with a lecture.
He told us this and he said that
and preached deep hatred to us:
Strike them dead, wherever they are,
then you remain free of the disease.
Consider also that the humid air,
is the best scent for the flies.
And close the doors quite nicely
and give the little fly-fishes quiet.
Above all things smear yourselves,
with Noxzema Cream.
It is supposed to be the best.
And while the speech went on and on,
the feud intensified again:
Do not confuse the flies,
there is a poem I want to say,
just listen, so that you may have peace!
And he recited full of diligence,
unfortunately I don't remember it,
but only the end, which is also important,
because the identification is always right:
If it stretches the abdomen high,
Anopheles is then detected!
Mysterious was this word,
very restless, we sneaked away.

But when we had gotten used to it,
greatest care was frowned upon after all.
Half naked we went bathing again.
What can the little bit of fly harm?
Quite late we still stepped in front of the house,
forgotten was the fly's horror.
Yes even in the room one remained cool,
even if the flies buzzed a lot.
That came because no one got sick,
one said, thanks to all the care,
which protected us from the suffering!
But if one wants to seize me as a heretic:
Oh please don't, I certainly believe
that Anopheles is dangerous!!!

Kirchner

FROM THE CULTURAL LIFE

Dermott, with about six to seven thousand German officers, naturally had more selection of specialists in every direction than Kenedy with its five hundred prisoners. The American Camp Administration was generous and had placed an entire company area with all barracks at the disposal of the Germans for teaching purposes. In addition, there was a large number of books, also technical literature of every kind, which was accessible to all prisoners. Every single man had, moreover, the possibility to order books of his free choice, so that one could read very much literature upon request.

Courses ran constantly for most academic professions, for theologians, lawyers, medical doctors, philosophers, philologists, natural scientists, farmers, technicians of almost every direction, painters, sculptors, and musicians. Pretty much all European languages were taught and learned. Several High School Diploma courses ran simultaneously and several hundred officers honestly earned the graduation certificate according to the existing Reich regulations, in spite of the oppressive heat in Arkansas, plus the humid air on the Mississippi, which often made the work a torture.

A large and high barrack, which offered twelve hundred seats, was Concert-, Theater- and Cinema-Room. On Sunday mornings the Protestant church service took place there.

Two music bands practiced constantly, a symphony orchestra of about sixty men and a brass band. Compositions by Beethoven, Haydn, Mozart, Schubert, Bach, and other masters were performed. The brass orchestra organized its concerts outdoors in the individual company areas. On Sundays after the church service, an excellent quartet offered half an hour of exquisite art enjoyment. The evening entertainments were provided by two dance orchestras. Furthermore, there were record concerts almost every Sunday. A well-adjusted men's choir sang above all at the Protestant church service. Once it gave a concert of pre-classical masters.

Well-known serious and hilarious theater pieces were performed; a world premiere "Kolumbus", was shown. Quite outstanding was the set design, which achieved

magnificent effects using simple devices. Generally admired were those comrades who had taken over the female roles and who portrayed them so deceptively that an ignorant spectator would not have thought that men were acting. Whether anyone fell in love with the "beauties" is not known to me.

The only German film we saw was "Friedrich Schiller." The American films were various, some good, some not appealing to us Germans. Regarding films we are spoiled; I do not believe that the world will reach German filmmaking in the foreseeable future - I think only of *Robert Koch*, the *Diesel-film* and similar ones. The performances suffered only from the fact that it was terribly hot and we sweated terribly, even if we opened windows and doors, as far as this was possible; the sweat nevertheless ran in little rivulets. It was even worse for the performing artists, the musicians, and actors.

One building had been refurbished as a chapel and diligent hands had magnificently decorated the interior. Both religious denominations held daily church service.

Individual regional groups met once a month - at such a gathering one of my students from High School and a Captain who had married a female student of mine once spoke to me. Furthermore, two of my classmates were in the camp.

The world is small after all!

Klug

YO-YO

How beautiful it was in camp at first,
one did not need to go to work.

But not for too long a time
did this glory last.

From above it was suddenly decided,
that from now on work should start.

And specifically in the group,
everyone should daily for one hour
take pity on the long grass
with arms that had become stiff.

This did not please us very much!

We received a handle,
on which an iron was attached.

And with our hollow stomach
we went out of our house
to get to work.

Here now we swung the device,
until no long stalk stands anymore.

After a week with much sweat,
for it was so terribly hot,
the last grass had fallen.

So now there existed among us all
only the wish for new rest.

But only now came the big clou.

The next morning they whistled us out:
The work was not done by a long shot,
the stalks were very high again,
where a week ago we had it cut.
So our hands never rested,
the work was always without end.
And if we were still there today,
we would be continuously "playing Yo - Yo".

Hoefffer

FIPS

Violent storm and rain make the POWs hurry to their barracks after the meager meal. But the small, helpless creature lying lamenting on the ground does not escape one of them. Quickly stooped and sheltered in the warm hand; that brings Fips into our community.

Krausch and Klein seem to be very suitable as foster parents, for Fips develops quite excellently. The first days he can hardly keep on his legs, but now he is already so well that he greedily holds his wide-open, insatiable beak towards the feeding hands. After not too long a time, he can already follow his foster parents on their hand into the open and thus accept the food directly in the hunting ground. Fips's activity is limited to stretching his little wings wide apart, with the first feathers beginning to grow and, cheeping with beak wide open, swallowing the grasshoppers carefully dissected into thighs, breast, and abdomen. He is becoming more fledged and cheeky now. At first, he only follows the callers for a few meters, until he finally follows the whole distance flying to the catching meadow, sitting there proudly and admonishingly at the same time on the shoulder of the eagerly searching and hunting foster father. Finally, one day the good Krausch - like the mother hen which could not follow her ducklings into the water - stands helplessly on the ground as his Fips sits on the wire and, despite all begging and pleading, makes no move to return to the familiar hand, especially since he is fat and had its fill. But the foster parents quickly found out that Fips, when he gets hungry, remorsefully appears again, and so even excursions into the neighborhood cause no more worries.

We always rejoice when Fips greets us after lunch at the barred window, wildly flapping his wings and scolding, and comes flying out the door as soon as it opens, to fly onto Krausch's shoulder and from there to the hunting ground. Once he has had his fill, he sits peacefully and contentedly like a real, well-behaved child at the feet of his caretakers, who are playing Skat (card game) in the open, and plays with small pebbles or even makes the first hunting attempts on grasshoppers, beetles, or flies coming by chance along the path.

Thus I will always keep our Fips in mind as a quiet, dear comforter and dispenser of joy, who let me forget many misunderstandings at least for a short time.

Kaufmann

HAVE NO TIME!

That the POW has much time,

is a complete untruthfulness.
This I must confess after all,
after I have seen it in Dermott.
Before the American Guard, striding fast,
came along the front for the roll count,
probably everyone had read with interest
the latest from the daily press.
The last bite was soon chewed.
Thus one still looked into the book,
until one pronounced "Mahlzeit" (Enjoy your meal)
and broke away from the table.
One was not at home for long.
With speed one went to classes,
learned for his studies
and then the morning was over.
In the afternoon one allowed oneself no rest;
barely closed the little eyes,
learned vocabulary of the English language
or crammed another subject.
In the evening everyone had his duty
and there was no shirking there.
One had to lay Solitaires,
cultivate friendships playing Doppelkopf (card game).
The last hour was barely enough
to go for another walk.
But it was necessary, the air was cool,
contrary to the day when it was very sultry.
Rest is sacred to man.
Only evil people are in a hurry!
But the POW loves honesty.
He really just has no time!!

Hoefffer

THE RARE CLOVERLEAF

After many long days,
One wanted to have work again,
because playing cards was no longer in fashion,
one gets bored beyond belief.
It finally happened in Dermott,
five Lieutenants have met there.
And since everyone had some inkling
of the beautiful arts, they founded the club
"The Cloverleaf". But, I beg you, no,
agriculture was not practiced there,
quite other things were preferred.
From the magician to the tenor

many other things took place.
They were intended for comrades,
who would like to take pleasure in them.
It was indeed a sensation.
And the most beautiful reward for all the efforts
showed itself soon in the success,
that none of the guests were angry.
They even came once more,
when "Soon" rang out in the small hall.
Yes, one spoke shortly in the whole land,
the metropolis Dermott became known.
Until the great farewell came,
which took away all possibilities,
to develop together again,
and shape the third evening.
Quite happy they were then,
when the first evening began
with a brilliant program,
according to a quite exact plan.
The spectators, they clapped cheerfully,
the entertainment became more colorful,
when the many wonders were shown -
and the humor made everyone happy.
And joyfully old warriors sang
again inspired with new courage
such beautiful, old-known songs
which knocked down all their homesickness.
The five, I want to report it now,
they were talented heroes.
Otto Pico, quite a genius,
Bartli Helmut, very real.
The President, Hans Pitt,
sang gladly along with Herr Nigrin.
As the last in the small round,
Mueller was part of the league.
All together they could do much,
and therefore reached their goal
to save from the barbed wire,
those whom it has caught.

Kirchner

THE POISONING

The food tasted really beautiful.
But what happened then,
was uncomfortable and a torment.
Of that I will now tell.

With a full belly one went to rest,
and closed one's eyes.
But one did not last long,
for something wanted out of the mouth.
Quickly and with distorted expression
one stormed to the latrine,
where in front of each of the seats,
one gave free run to the feeling.
This was the first prank,
but the second followed right away,
for the intestines' painfulness
announces: It is high time!
So the body threw everything up
becoming limp and empty thereby.
They brought us to the Hospital,
to end this torture.
Was it the sausage, was it the salad,
which has poisoned us?
Or was it only the coffee?
No one ever solved the matter.
Since from the company very many
fell victim to this nausea,
it was only a small group,
that was cheerful and merry.
These unharmed people
thought full of malicious joy:
The dinner will be worth it
with the sick people's portions.
But the dream of giant masses
had to be dropped soon.
as for the still intact stomachs
only milk soups were served.

Hoeffler

WORK CALLS

It was in the month of September,
we were driven to departure again,
in the known large crowds
to dwell in one compartment.
This time we knew for sure
that we would not go back to Germany yet.
The signature on the paper
indicated that there is still work here.
So we then spoke of K-Rations,
in which cigarettes dwell,
and chocolate, delicious, fine;

it can indeed be different for once.
The train drove rapidly; it drove fast
how many miles are there still
Until Idaho in the high North?
For urgently we are needed there.
Soon the area was unknown,
curiously we looked at the land
in Wyoming and Oklahoma,
in Kansas and in Colorado.
At first still steppe, large and wide,
sometimes a tree in loneliness.
Then mountains approached quietly:
The Rocky Mountains began.
And higher and higher they became,
quite often one never saw the crests.
Most were snow-covered,
which awoke nostalgia in us.
After many hours it went downhill,
pleasing this was indeed.
Why should we dwell up here;
where there was certainly nothing to feast on.
In Idaho, so we heard,
was a new base quarter.
Rupert was the name of this camp,
where evil dogs bite hard.
Soon we heard the barking too,
the escape plan was discarded quickly!
Obediently we walked in step
along with all the many dogs.
The stay was not long here.
With work they made us scared,
so heavy and dirty, unthinkable,
that we could manage it.
Again with a lot of K-Rations,
we strove to a new destination.
Montana, the neighboring state at right,
the place that has work for us.
There we finally arrived,
and soon the work began.
Also of that we want to report,
in the form of funny poems!

Kirchner

THE RAM DISPUTE

It is a beautiful thing
with one's dear mother tongue.

Everyone learns as much as he can,
everyone wishes this for himself.
For this there is a Duden (dictionary),
which avoids all cursing,
all arguing, scolding, screaming,
if you know nothing, then look in there.
Recently a dispute had arisen,
which we all felt very much.
Are the "Hammel" [rams] Pluralhammel?
One asks this with stuttering.
No, the "Hammel", that's how it is right,
others act very important about it.
until a third one with force,
urges them to silence soon.
Smiling he reaches for the Duden,
he does not have to search for long at all.
Radiant is his face,
as he speaks wisely thereupon:
O, you rams [idiots], look here,
plural form of the ram animal,
are "die Hammel" - but it is important -,
that "die Hammel" is also correct.

Kirchner

COMRADES?

Whether in the South, or in the North,
hordes always remain hordes.
Discipline, there you have gone to hell;
Who still has doubts about that?
Exceptions only prove the rule,
Harmless ones - like white sails -
exist too, unfortunately only few,
but everyone acts like a king. -
Recently, when we lay in Rupert,
some people got very fed up,
for clothing, beautiful and much,
was the thieves ideal goal.
Ruthlessly and cheerfully they stole;
since the confusion became chaotic
already after some time,
they were immune to being seen.
Coats, trousers, tunics, socks,
gloves made of leather lured them,
underwear, large in numbers
made them waver their decisions.
Quickly eight socks - like in a frenzy -

four of them for exchange with tobacco.
Everyone calls, everyone screams!
Is that supposed to be comradeship? ---
Dignity, posture one learns
as a recruit in the barracks.
Unfortunately it looks, oh horror,
quite different in the world.

Kirchner

ONLY THE SUGAR BEETS ARE TO BLAME!

Sugar is always a special treat,
If one does not have to work for it.
For no one loves the work.
Only the sugar beets are to blame!
Why does one work in bent positions,
To pull the beets and then to knock them?
Couldn't one sieve sugar out of water?
Only the sugar beets are to blame!
Who had to invent work?
Has one not already slaved enough?
Why is it not driven by machines?
Only the sugar beets are to blame!
The whistle sounds, the day begins.
It is not raining, off to the field we go then.
One would have rather stayed in bed.
Only the sugar beets are to blame!
Outside is frost, the feet are freezing.
The cold strikes the intestines and kidneys.
The ice-cold hands are rubbed.
Only the sugar beets are to blame!
One runs through the rows, pulls and pulls,
until the back hurts and every limb.
For this we have signed up!
Only the sugar beets are to blame!
So it goes to topping, the knife drawn,
That also works only when one bends over.
The arms swell from many blows.
Only the sugar beets are to blame!
From early on it goes like this until evening late.
How slowly time passes after all!
When the work is over, it's already seven.
Only the sugar beets are to blame.
A truck brings us home.
Too slowly only, it is a horror!
It would be best if one pushed it.
Only the sugar beets are to blame!

One sits by the stove, whose warmth delights,
And speaks of beets, very long and very broad,
What one did the whole day.
Only the sugar beets are to blame!
Soon one lies flat on the bunk.
One has had nothing from the long day.
The work alone remained for us.
Only the sugar beets are to blame!
Already one snores and rattles in chorus,
The one in Bass, the other Tenor.
One dreams of the field, not of loving.
Only the sugar beets are to blame!

Hoefffer

THE BEST WATER IN THE WORLD!

Warmest regards from Montana,
Prisoner, if you come to Laurel, do not miss drinking there,
The best water in the world. Fuchs serves it to you gladly.
Laurel's blessed fields produce the world's best beets,
Sugar content like never before, almost hundred percent.
Therefore, get up you POWs, steer your steps to Montana.
Let us hack away, backaches do not exist there.
Konrad from Park City says: "The diarrhea surely comes from the food
that you get from me, for it is quite fatty."
"Konrad, you are very mistaken, the diarrhea comes at most from the water,
that you bring us so eagerly and often into the row.
Beet-Dwarf's wagon appears on the field for the daily estimation,
how many tons the field must deliver today for the crop.

Koenig.

OUR FARMERS

For me quite nice and interesting,
how did they find our farmers.
Time to ponder, there was plenty
and one mostly reached the conclusion.
There were some, fine humans,
who made no boundaries with us,
to give us soup or sausage,
or also coffee for the thirst.
They themselves, they spoke almost like us,
although they were here already many a year
and mostly never saw German land.
Nevertheless, they knew that it is beautiful.
Another one, closefisted by nature,
gave water, only because he had to.
But this water, it was good

and gave courage again and again!
A third, he gladly gave tobacco
from his great wealth.
When the nose first smells the smoke,
that helps also for the hunger.
Also there were many "noble humans",
when we reached the day's goal,
they gave cigarettes to us,
which taste very good as "active" ones.
Another farmer, he was smart,
he gave us enough to eat.
There we chopped vigorously too
and cut up small all beets.
It was quite beautiful, we are satisfied,
even if we love other work more.
But if the farmer just has humor,
the work seems easier to us.

Kirchner

QUIET! LIGHTS OUT!

In the Reibert [Soldier's Manual] it is written,
that the soldier must love order.
And to strive for this,
the order was given,
Lights out and quiet be from ten [10 PM].
Then everyone had to go to bed,
since from the beet hoeing
everyone is early tired.
One could not avoid,
undressing himself still later.
And since everything was already dark,
he let the lamp sparkle bright.
Hardly was this deed accomplished,
when most of the men woke up,
and screamed with all physical strength:
Turn the light out! You!!
Frightened by this great noise,
others were woken up too,
who were already sleeping in sweet slumber,
so that these called again:
Quiet! This screaming in the night,
makes indeed every soul awake!
Everyone in the house became lively
and the noise became more and more chaotic.
One roared at each other then
and only the late coming man,

who had already been overlooked,
could go quietly to his bed,
after the light did extinguish.
Since the dispute has no purpose anymore,
one could finally close the daily course!
One should never uselessly make a fuss!
(No signature, however the style could be from Kirchner or Höfer)

SEAFARER'S GERMAN LANGUAGE

It is clear for some people,
that everyone is a big fool,
who cannot speak in Sailor-Slang,
and they take terrible revenge on him.
It is quite difficult for the Infantryman,
who is otherwise used to reporting - "Here" -,
if he now suddenly has to report - "show clear" -,
until now, he only knew - clear screens -.
That -Kojé- is now the name of our bed,
we soon find terribly nice ourselves.
But if it should ever come to betting,
we would all vote for the word "beds".
-Clean ship made- oh what a mockery,
afore the broom runs away.
How are we supposed to clean the bunks,
if all ship cleaning tools are on mutiny.
If Skipper's Ship is to be cleaned
upon a whistle, that is called "Reinschiff"
Now – we say goodbye to room duty,
since we are on the high seas!
What is the Galley, where is the Stern,
the Mess Officer is lost for words.
Make clear, soon things will get rough
isn't Navy life very pretty!?
And the moral of the story,
the Old Salt does not disturb the Soldier.
He cannot make an impression with it,
At most, he can bring others to laughing.

Kirchner

THE WAITING ONES

A long house made of many beams,
three stoves inside. That's how it looked,
when we arrived in the camp
with the name Pocatello.
We came here with fifty men,
and much more it could not be,

for in the house's spaciousness,
the room was not very large.
Everyone had to receive a bed,
and to obtain the best one,
there was immediately a big hunt,
where the beds lay in clusters.
Two men took a board,
wiped clouds of dust away
and laid on it, what during the course
of the day one must use.
One took a stone now in the hand,
hit a few nails into the wall,
namely to use these
for coat, tunic and shirts.
The duffel bag stayed as it was,
For it was completely clear to everyone,
we would not stay here very long,
until the journey home should start.
We did not set up further,
for one would be the last,
if suddenly the departure day came
and everything lay in confusion.
But still we are here,
in the fifty-man-quarter.
The duffel bag is still full and thick,
for we are supposed to go back home.

Hoeffler

DISAPPOINTMENTS!

On all these pages there was
not a word of that which one does not like.
But it also belongs to POW times,
therefore, let some of it come to light.
I want to speak in the following now
of one thing, that you all know,
it took revenge on us quite often;
quite simply one calls it "Disappointment".
Already on the journey to the camp,
one could hear with astonishment,
the minds were set on outdoor pool, sports field;
the other things bothered them little.
And just arrived in the camp,
they immediately looked at the water tanks,
there is much quarreling over delicious ice.-
Disappointment hit not the best ones here.
First it was only the Camp's Spokesman,

who annoyed the masses.
He found, however, Major avengers;
the others ironically commented on it.
Then it was the turn of the Adjutants,
who had to yield to the "Wishes";
they changed often, man after man.-
Disappointment always reached us.
A barrack was made available to us,
for "Recreation" it was supposed to count.
The furnishing had been ordered long ago,
one hears the Adjutant scolding.
Of that which came, one does not like to speak,
there were few, meager chunks.
"The masses" never appealed to me.-
Disappointment remained with them.
The workshop, with dust of the saws,
was visited by everyone,
in whom diligence stirred;
everyone could get at the tools,
who wanted to saw something or carve,
then he tool lay blunt and wild around,
scattered on all tables and, seats:
Thus Disappointment made me mute.
Because the mail did not come for so long,
for which everyone waits with longing,
one received the Red Card ,
so that it starts homewards again.
The time however passed, elapsed,
it crept along, like a thief.
Of our loved ones we saw not a line:
Disappointment remained as the only thing.
So it was with the departure too,
from which one devised the journey home;
thus the English exam's was the new practice,
after which the lazy ones woke up;
So it was with the apple harvest,
which we had hoped for as a power game.
If we put it together now:
Disappointment fell upon disappointment.
Arrived in the land of work,
we already had heard of German farmers;
we did hope for understanding,
but reality became as a mockery to us.
And for the harvest's good yield
they promised us an easy journey home.
The prisoner's newest finding:

Disappointment will never depart from us.
 So it will go on in life,
 no matter where and what you are.
 Fate will give you blows,
 which you rarely forget so quickly.
 But one thing one can calmly note,
 that one often drives expectation far.
 This can perhaps strengthen you cheaply:
 Mostly the result: Disappointment will remain.
Kaufmann

KREUZ UND QUER DURCH AMERIKA (Crisscrossing through America)
 1944.10.2 – 1944.10.6

Date	Location	City Pop.	State	State Pop.
2.10.	Boston (16.30)	770,000	Massachusetts	4,316,000
	Providence	253,000	Rhode Island	713,000
	New London	-	-	-
	Albany	130,000	New York	13,479,000
3.10.	Utica	100,000	"	"
	Syracuse	205,000	"	"
	Rochester	324,000	"	"
	Batavia	17,000	"	"
	Buffalo	575,000	"	"
	Erie	116,000	Pennsylvania	9,900,000
	Cleveland	878,000	Ohio	6,900,000
4.10.	St. Louis	816,000	Missouri	3,784,000
	Bismarck	1,300	"	"
	Poplar Bluff	11,000	"	"
	Newport	3,000	Arkansas	1,900,000
	Little Rock	88,000	"	"
5.10.	Texarkana	11,000	Texas	6,400,000
	Dallas	294,000	"	"
	Houston	384,000	"	"
6.10.	Kenedy (6.30)	700	"	"

17-18 (Erie) , Kenedy。1940

2. Fahrt Kenedy - Dermott
 1945.6.11 – 1945.6.13

Date	Location	Pop.	State	State Pop.
11.6.	Kenedy (10.10)	700	Texas	6,400,000

Date	Location	Pop.	State	State Pop.
	Shiner	1,500	"	
	Hearne	3,500	"	
	Grossbeck (Groesbeck)	2,200	"	
	Corsikana (Corsicana)	15,000	"	
	Ennis	7,000	"	
	Dallas	294,000	"	
12.6	Grand Saline	1,500	"	
	Mineola	3,200	"	
13.6	Gladewater	-	-	
	Longview	13,700	"	
	Marshall	18,000	"	
	Atlanta	3,400	"	
	Texarkana	17,000	"	
	Hope	7,000	Arkansas	1,900,000
	Prescott	3,100	"	
	Pine Bluff	21,000	"	
	Dermott (21.00)	3,000	"	

1945.6Dermott

3. Fahrt Dermott - Rupert

194.10.1 – 1945.10.3

Date	Location	Pop.	State	State Pop.
1.10	Dermott (15.00)	3,000	Arkansas	1,900,000
	Pine Bluff	21,000	"	
	Little Rock	88,000	"	
2.10	Fort Gibson	1,000	Oklahoma	2,230,000
	Neodesha	3,300	Kansas	1,800,000
	Kansas City	121,000	Kansas	
	St. Joseph	75,000	Missouri	3,700,000
3.10	Rulo	800	Nebraska	1,315,000
	McCook	6,000	"	
	Brush	2,400	Colorado	1,123,000

Date	Location	Pop.	State	State Pop.
	Denver	322,000	"	
	Lasalle	775	"	
	Ault	760	"	
	Laramie	10,000	Wyoming	250,000
4.10	Rawlins	5,000	"	
	Rock Springs	9,800	"	
	Kemmerer	2,000	"	
	Montpelier	2,500	Idaho	524,000
	Lava Hot Springs	650	"	
	Pocatello	18,000	"	
	Rupert (14.00)	3,000	"	

Date (1946)	Location (Ort)	State/Notes
16.1.	Pocatello (10.00) -> Rupert (17.00)	Idaho (Truck ride / Fahrt mit LKW)
1.2.	Rupert (23.45)	Departure by train
2.2.	Cämmerer (Kemmerer), Green River, Rock Springs, Rawlins, Laramie, Cheyenne	Wyoming
3.2.	Sidney, Fremont, Omaha	Nebraska
	Council-Bluffs, Fort Dodge, Waterloo	Iowa
4.2.	Chicago	Illinois
	Rochester, Huntington, Fort Wayne, Marion	Indiana
5.2.	Mansfield, Cleveland	Ohio
	Jamestown, Salamanka, Olean, Hornell, Susquehanna, Middletown	New York
	Orangeburg (Camp Shanks) (10.00)	New York (22 miles NNW of NYC)

 **Historical Note: Camp Shanks Port of Embarkation** , "Last Stop USA".

6. Transatlantic Crossing)

1946.2.10 – 1946.2.21

Date (1946)	Event / Location	Note
10.2.	Camp Shanks (7.30) -> New York (14.00)	Boarding
	Auslaufen mit "Victory" (23.30)	Departing on a "Victory ship"

Date (1946)	Event / Location	Note
18.2.	Englische Küste (22.00)	Sighted English Coast
19.2.	Festland in Sicht (13.45) / Reede von Le Havre	Mainland in sight / Le Havre roadstead
20.2.	Anker hängt an Unterwasserkabel	Anchor stuck on underwater cable
21.2.	Ausschiffen (13.30)	Disembarking
	Zwischenlager "Heinrichbogen"	Transit Camp (France)

7. (France & Handover)

1946.22 – 1946.3.20

Date (1946)	Location	Notes
22.2.	Le Havre -> Amiens	
23.2.	Compiègne, Crèpy-en-Valois, Villers Cotterets, Soissons	
24.2.	Attichy (14.00)	US POW Camp in France (CPM 15)
	<i>2 1/2 km Fussmarsch ins Lager</i>	March into camp
15.3.	Abmarsch Attichy (18.10)	Leaving Attichy
16.3.	Sedan, Montmedy, Saarbrücken	Entering Germany (French Zone?)
17.3.	Marburg/Lahn	
19.3.	Bebra (1. freier Ausgang... auf ein Glas Bier)	A brief moment of freedom/beer?
20.3.	Abfahrt (11.30) -> Eisenach W.	Critical Point: Eisenach was on the border of the Soviet Zone.
	Übergabe des Transportes an Vopo	Handover to "People's Police" (Soviet Zone)

Critical Note: 113 Eisenach, Vopo (Volkspolizei),

8. (Soviet Captivity)

1946.3 – 1949.11

	Location / Event	Historical Context
	Weimar Ankunft (12.00)	Arrival in Weimar
	Erfurt-Entlausungsanstalt	Delousing station
	Lager Topf & Söhne	Camp at the factory that made crematoriums
	Erfurt -> Leipzig -> Berlin	Handover to Russian Guard
	Oranienburg (Entladen)	Unloading at Oranienburg

	Location / Event	Historical Context
	Einlass in KZ	Entry into Concentration Camp (Sachsenhausen was used by Soviets as Special Camp No. 7)
	Nach Russland verschleppt	Deported to Russia
	Verladen (Loading)	
	Frankfurt/Oder	Border city to Poland
	Verladen (Loading)	Likely transfer to broad-gauge train
	Otschernekidze (Ordzhonikidze)	Now Vladikavkaz (North Ossetia)
	Passhöhe der gross. Heerstraße am Kasbeck	Georgian Military Road / Mount Kazbek
	Gori, Tiflis (Tbilisi), Rustavi	Georgia / Caucasus Region
	1949	Three years later...
	Frankfurt / Oder	Return to East Germany
	Pforzheim	Final Release / Home!

P.W. 31G 15 294

Alois Klug, born June 2, 1899

Munich-Solln, Ottilienstr. 15 c/o Dr. Wetzel

P.W. 31G 15 296

Heinz Kirchner, born July 20, 1920

Leipzig, Bieselburg 11.

P.W. 31G 15 297

Rudolf König, born Jan 29, 1911

Lübeck, Wielandstr. 3

P.W. 31G 15 304

Helmut Kaufmann, Aug 26, 1917

Pforzheim, Kronprinzenstr. 58

P.W. 31G 15 521

Wilhelm König, born Dec 13, 1916

Siegburg on the Sieg, Zeithstraße 21

P.W. 31G 704 323

Ernst-Günther Hoeffler, Aug 28, 1921

Lübeck, Hoflandstr. 52

Remark by K. Schramm:

Remark K. Schramm: FROM PAGE 139 to 143 in the original document there are Crossword Puzzles etc. - I have not done them.

High night of the clear stars,
that stand like wide bridges
over a deep distance,
over which our hearts go.
From a Christmas song.

Does it not seem as if these lines were written for us, for us who are far from home, far from loved ones, separated by immeasurable expanses and unfathomable depths, waiting – waiting for the longed-for return home! Often we stand alone or with a like-minded comrade under the starry sky and search in the sparkle up there for the familiar constellations of home. Absorbed in the contemplation of the world of stars, things around us and within us transform in a wonderful way.

The barbed wire fences, drawn manifold and tight, no longer constrict. The spotlight, high and glaring, becomes meaninglessly dim before the sparkling glory reflected in our eyes. The weight that day and time have laid upon our souls is taken from us as if by a soft hand. Light and free, we breathe deeply the pure night air.

The silver wagon in the firmament takes up our longing and carries it, overcoming space and time, safely over the swinging bridge of stars, the path that leads into the hearts of loved ones at home. This longing seeks touch, fulfillment, and finds it confirmed. "Almost every night I stand at the window and send you greetings through our beloved constellations. I cannot imagine that countries and seas separate us, so close are you often to me, my dear."

Christmas Essay - The Starry Sky (Part 2) & The Circle of Friends

Often the wagon drew its heavenly course since we first made it the messenger of our wishes. Days, weeks, and months passed. The world changed its face and grew old with grief from what it had to see.

But now Christmas approaches again!

Christmas Eve lays its gentle darkness also over our camp at the foot of the great Rocky Mountains in the West. On the way home from Midnight Mass to our shared accommodation, we look up to the faithful messengers in the sky. More certainly than ever before, they connect us today across all distances with the beloved people at home. In the heartbeat, we believe we feel the harmony, the oneness with them. As we now detach our gaze from the stars and go inside, a warm glow remains in our eyes. We carry it inside as a quiet, happy light into our small circle, which begins with **Alois Klug**, rounds itself out with **Heinz Kirchner**, **Willi Koenig**, **Helmut Kaufmann**, **Ernst-Guenther Hoeffler**, and finally closes with **Rolf Koenig**. The distant loved ones are near us, the past becomes living reality, as we now begin to tell of Christmas at home.

POW-Camp Pocatello/Idaho, Christmas 1945.

IN THE GIANT MOUNTAINS

Thick, heavy fogs lie for weeks in the long-stretched mountain valleys, enveloping with their milky bleak masses the simple wooden houses that stand on the slopes of gently rising heights on both sides of swiftly rushing brooks. They cover with their lazy drifting swathes the dark-green spruce forests that adjoin harvested fields,

light-green crops, or dark-brown meadows, and only the highest peaks of the mountains or the domes covered with scrub pine rise like islands out of the surging and seething sea of fog.

Mother sun draws her daily course lower and lower, hardly blinking through the walls of fog around noon, without power and without warmth. Until deep into the morning, the sinking night lingers, only to pull the following sister with a gray-dark hand after a short break at midday.

In the twilight of the gathering evening, a wild Northeaster has woken up. It whistles and roars in grim anger over the high, blocking mountain wall, rolls its whipped air masses in furious haste through the narrow valleys, snaps strong trees in the forests, uproots others that it cannot break, and rages like a wildly hunting pack around the dwellings of the mountain people, howls mockingly in the chimneys, tears the rising smoke plumes into shreds, throws whole clouds of rain into the faces of people walking lonely on the country road, and combines with the darkness rising from the ground into a horror that grips sensitive people by the heart.

In the isolated, low wooden houses, wax candles burn in the darkness, which creeps through the small windows into the parlors; a flickering fire crackles in the chimneys, constantly nourished by resin-scented pine wood. White-haired grandmothers sit in the circle of their family and neighbors and tell of days long past or begin ancient fairy tales with - "Once upon a time..." - for the listening children. Fir-green Advent wreaths shine in the gold of their decorative ribbons over white-covered tables, on which red-cheeked apples are displayed. Grandfather has taken his seat on the cozy stove bench, the wooden pipe in his wrinkled mouth, the sharp carving knife in his hand. Beside him lie soft linden woods. Deliberately, his skillful, albeit already shaky hand leads cut after cut, outlines the figures of shepherds and sheep and gives them form and life, while his ear listens to the story of his spouse or his memory runs years back to a time when he still chased through woods and meadows as a wild lad or sat as a boy at his grandmother's feet, just as the grandchildren do now, and listened until the Sandman let him slumber away blissfully.

And let the storm howl outside ever so much, the Christ Child's near birth gilds the dreary time. One day winter climbs over the mountains. Lead-gray, white-edged clouds hang low in the sky, like thick feather beds from which Mother Hulda wants to shake white feathers. The wild fellow from midnight (the North wind) has laid himself to rest, the heavy fog has sunk to the ground, and now, in the evening twilight, large snowflakes fall to the earth, slowly, quietly, peacefully, solemnly. It snows throughout the long night and early in the morning paths and footbridges, meadows and forests, houses and churches are deeply snowed in, covered with a soft, gentle upholstered bed. A deep peace lies over the landscape and only the smoke rising from the chimneys shows life. Patiently the forest trees stand, as if they were rejoicing in the glittering jewelry on their branches. Fearfully deer and roe deer come to the feeding troughs, while the Hare dares, like the hungry little birds, to seek food near humans. Bright jingling of bells mixes with the exuberant neighing of rested horses, happy children's cheers echo from the slopes, on which small sleds rush valley-ward at lightning speed. The nights stretch longer and longer, the days live only in a miserable twilight. The quiet becomes more and more mysterious;

it is as if nature were withdrawing, as if she wanted to lay a thick veil around the birth of the light, as if forest and field and all life remained silent in awe before the birth of the new life and of the Son of God.

December 24th. Even if the day peels itself out of the twilight foggy and gloomy, hearts are full of happy anticipation.

In the morning hours of the gloomily dawning day, it begins to snow. No little breeze disturbs the play of the falling flakes. In all parlors, there is scrubbing and washing. A fine scent of fresh fir resin and crispy baked goods moves continually through the rooms.

With difficulty, the father drags the heavy Christmas Crib from the hayloft, fastens it with strong wires to the wooden beams of the parlor ceiling and begins, surrounded by children beaming with happiness, with the construction of the city of Bethlehem. He places the stable in a rock grotto, artistically formed from pieces of bark, groups the holy persons around the manger with the Child, lets angels of heaven, shepherds, and sheep announce the glad tidings on rocky pastures, while the gift-bearers set out on the way to the manger.

There is, of course, also damage to heal. A shepherd has lost his blowing horn, a little sheep stands with difficulty on three legs, the night watchman of the city of Bethlehem has broken off his spear, presumably during an official act, not while sleeping - no wonder, given that the bad boys meanwhile smashed in the windows of the town hall - the chimney sweep is much too bright, he probably hasn't worked much lately, and so there is a lot to mend. The glue pot stands ready for service on the stove, in which the fire does not go out today. Unfortunately, the helpful fingers usually stick better to each other than the hats, legs, or ears to the figures.

At the table, the mother has meanwhile made all preparations for stretching the Strudel dough. Amazed, the children stand around the marvel and one after the other tries to snatch some of the delicacies that are being spread on the dough.

While this brave fellow browns in the oven heat, it is the Christmas tree's turn to be decorated. Glittering glass balls, bells, and wooden fruits, chocolate wrapped in silver-shining foil, homemade nut rings, red-cheeked apples, gilded walnuts, radiant stars, and white-glittering tinsel chains are fastened to the green branches or laid upon them. Finally, the mother sticks white candles onto the needles and throws tinsel from branch to branch.

From the towers of the village churches, bells call into the solemnly rising twilight: It is Christmas, it is Christmas! And rest and peace move with the fading bell tones over mountains and valleys, over meadows and forests, and stop in with all people who are of good will.

On the white-covered table, candles burn in wooden holders. The family kneels around the Christmas tree and prays aloud for all the living and the deceased, also for those of whom no one thinks anymore. Devoutly the father reads from the Holy Scripture the loveliest story that was ever written. Then the family silently takes their seats at the table and eats the Christmas Strudel. After the meal, the mother carries the leftovers into the stable and into the garden. Today every creature celebrates the birth of the Lord, the stars in the sky, the plants in forest and field, the animals in the stable or under the sky, and everything that wears a human face; one God, one Lord, one Creation. Quietly burn the Christmas tree candles and the small, colored

lamp by the manger; devoutly the youth stand before the secret of life, while the thoughts of the parents rush back into the times when they themselves still celebrated the Holy Night as children with their parents. Small gifts bring new joys. Outside, a starry sky shines over the mountains, more beautiful, larger, and more radiant than usual. Quietly the mountain people set out for the midnight mass. No word shall disturb the holy silence that lies over the mountains. In happy solitude, they trudge through the deep snow. From the distant little church, the bells call once more: It is Christmas, it is Christmas! into the resting mountain world, and soon the nocturnal pilgrims see muffled light shimmering through the painted windows of their house of God. From the tower, musicians blow the melody of "Silent Night, Holy Night" into the solemn peace of this holy night. With tender flute tones, the organ takes over the song and, childlike happy, the congregation sings the dear Christmas carol before the solemn service begins. Violins, clarinets, trumpets, and timpani mix into the festival joy that roars through the mass and finds its climax in "Holy God, We Praise Thy Name".

With deep Christmas joy in their hearts and quieter even than when they came, the mountain people return home to their houses, in which the little lamp before the manger casts a cozy glow through the whole night onto the God-child born at midnight.

A consecrated solemnity and a holy peace lie over the snow-covered, dreamy mountain home.

ON THE UPPER RHINE

December 15th.

Violently, an icy cold wind swept through the village streets, danced over harvested gardens, and knocked imperiously on the windows and doors of the small houses. It came as a harbinger of winter and was stern and cold, like its master himself. Mercilessly, it wiped away the traces of autumn. Yes, even the brown color of the earth did not suit it, and it fetched the long-promised snowflakes from Frau Holle to wrap the landscape in a new dress.

For the villagers, this was no surprise. A long time ago, one had adjusted to winter, yes, one had even expected it. Just as one waits for a birthday, or for Christmas. Only winter was rarely very punctual. But now it could come. Sturdy footwear stood ready, and thick coats and warm stockings were within reach. And did not good coals and other heating material lie in the cellars, ready to protect against excessive cold? Yes, even sleds and snowshoes were already waiting, prepared by impatient children's hands for days for the beginning of winter.

December 16th.

A wonderfully beautiful Advent Sunday lured young and old outside. Confident ones took their sleds with them immediately, although only a light veil of snow lay on the ground. But most were drawn to the few shop windows in the village, which showed the most magnificent pre-Christmas splendor. In lavish abundance, all imaginable treasures were displayed, and many a secret wish stirred in the hearts of the onlookers. Yes, not infrequently fathers and mothers admired just as longingly as their children, who usually could only be brought away from the displays with all sorts of promises.

In the evening, candles burned in every house. It was the third Advent.
December 17th.

The last week before Christmas has begun. It belongs to the special character of this week that one feels and hears this everywhere.

Darkness still lies over the village as I enter the train station. The few students who, like me, travel to school on the early train, sit on a bench in the sparsely lit waiting room. No conversation wants to arise; everyone pursues their own thoughts. And all of these circle around Christmas.

The train lets us wait a long time today. When it comes, we get in mechanically. Here and there a greeting is exchanged. Otherwise, everything is quiet. Sleepily everyone leans in a corner. Finally, we are moving. I try to cast a glance through the window. It does not succeed, for they are frozen, and I can only observe the strange figures of the frost flowers, on which the light reflects in manifold ways. I half-close my eyes and see nothing but burning Christmas trees.

December 20th.

Last school day. As I enter the classroom, candles are burning. The desk and blackboard are decorated with fir branches. The otherwise so dismal room was conjured into a festival hall.

The Lower Third Form (Untertertia) is celebrating Christmas!

Everyone looks full of tension and expectation at the door, which can open at any moment. No one thinks of the report cards that we will get two hours later! When our class teacher enters, he is surprised. We see it in his eyes. He looks from one to the other and greets us with a solemn voice.

The head boy strikes up a song with his violin; we all sing along vigorously: "O Rejoice, Christendom!" Later the teacher tells stories, Christmas experiences from the Great War [WWI]. Rarely was the class as attentive as in this hour.

December 22nd.

When an event casts its shadows ahead, then it is Christmas. Work and preparations do not cease in these last days. There is scrubbing and wiping, washing and cleaning, until everything shines in new cleanliness. Although all hands are active, one sees almost no end.

Later than last year, our fir tree comes into the house. It is a small, slender tree, evenly grown, with dark green needles. A tart, fresh scent streams from all branches. It too must be decorated today. But only late in the evening we get to do it. Even though the Sandman is already going around, my sister bravely fights against tiredness. For she must be there, too. Eagerly she unwraps the Christmas tree balls from their careful packaging and hands them to Mother. And now a happy rivalry arises, until after a short time the tree already stands there in its magnificent splendor. No candles are burning yet, but wondrously the light reflects on balls and silver threads.

While the Sandman knocks for the second time, the tree vanishes from our sight for two days.

December 23rd.

Overnight snow has fallen again. Path and footbridge lie snow covered, and only a snowplow makes the streets usable. Frau Holle meant it too well, but the children are grateful for the rich blessing. No sled stays at home today, no snowshoe stands

still. The otherwise quiet main street has become a large playground. Incessantly, sled upon sled whizzes past the town hall into the valley, and whoever does not participate themselves stands by the street and observes the colorful picture. Quickly the noon hours pass. While it becomes quieter again on the streets, darkness softly falls. But no one thinks of tiredness. After all, the church congregation is celebrating its Christmas festival today, on the fourth Advent. And is it not the festival of the whole village?

Solemnly the bells ring down into the valley, while parents and children find the way to the house of God.

For several Sundays, the boys and girls of the village had practiced eagerly to organize the Christmas festival for the grown-ups. And gratefully the grown-ups came to delight themselves in the joy of the little ones.

Gloriously shines a large tree of lights in the church, around which the village people now gather. And mightily the choral sounds down from the organ: "Lift up your heads, ye mighty gates. The King of Glory waits!" The voices sound brighter, the eyes become more shining and hands fold more intimately in prayer. Christmas! Birth of Light! Birth of Truth!

December 24th.

This day began rainy. Overnight a mild warm wind had set in, which robbed the yesterday still so beautiful snow landscape of almost all its white magic. In addition, a fine rain trickled since the early morning hours, which softened streets and paths in an instant.

Notwithstanding this, a busy life prevailed everywhere. More hurriedly than usual, young and old went through the streets to take care of last purchases. Only rarely and reluctantly did one stop for a chat today; everyone had their secrets.

Quieter than usual, it was in the parents' home. Mysteriously, the door of the living room opened and closed now and then, but what was going on behind it remained a secret to our children's eyes for the time being. From hour to hour, the tension grew greater.

The afternoon cleared up and for hours the sun shone, as if it too wanted to distinguish this day. While the clock shows the fourth hour of the afternoon, the twilight already begins. The sky still shows the last traces of the vanishing day, when the bells of the city of Basel begin to ring. The many churches and chapels greet the Holy Eve with their peal of bells, which the wind carries to us in the neighboring border village. On the streets, people stop; in the houses, windows are opened and devoutly the village listens to the swelling and fading tones.

Wondrously sound the bells of the Minster with their triad. But only for a few minutes alone, then the sisters from the city church also ring, and the many larger and smaller ones follow, together greeting the Holy Eve.

Meanwhile, it has become completely dark. Quietly lie the streets and alleys, only occasionally belated pedestrians hasten to their dwelling. Now and then one hears bright jingling right up into the houses. Then we all know, the Christ Child and the Santa Claus are on their way. Curious children's eyes peer through the windows. Restlessly their hearts beat when a muffled figure appears in the light of the street lamps. Is the Christ Child coming to us this year too?

But the anxious waiting lasts only a short time. Closer and closer sounds the bell,

knocking at the front door, clattering steps on the stairs, soft whispering in the hallway. Mother takes us siblings by the hand. Curiously I listen out into the hall, fearfully my sister presses herself to Mother. Then the door opens and Father fetches us into the living room.

Searching eyes fall on the lighted Christmas Tree and on the Christ Child. Santa Claus stands humbly behind the tree. Flickering candlelight falls on his large white beard, on his red-trimmed hood and his dark coat. Quietly the door closes behind us.

A light voice asks if we have been good. Santa Claus opens his thick book and reads out our register of sins. But it could not be too large, for only recently Knecht Ruprecht was here, and since then we were "better" than ever. Still, my sister looks around fearfully. Her gaze hangs on the large cane that Santa Claus carries with him. But when he brings out his gifts, all anxiety disappears. While my sister presses her new doll to herself, she recites her poem.

She is still speaking the last words, when I reach for the violin and begin our Christmas song: "Silent Night, Holy Night..." Everyone sings along; even Santa Claus with his rough, deep voice. Again and again, my eyes seek the tree, the burning candles, which are reflected a thousandfold in the silver and gold shining decorations. Hour of Light! Hour of Joy!

When I have finished, we are alone. Unnoticed, the Christ Child and his companion have left us.

Now follows the gift-giving ceremony with its manifold joys and surprises. Everyone fetches their gifts from their hiding places, to delight themselves in the joy of the presentees. Oh Festival of Joy; uncountable are the people, whom you make content! Oh Festival of Love; innumerable are the people whom you make happy. Mother reads the Christmas story of the Child in the Manger. We listen to the old familiar tale, while the candles slowly burn down. Our thoughts rush over times to the stable of Bethlehem and accompany the three Magi from the Orient to see the Child and to adore it.

It has become late. Long ago the candles were extinguished, but they still shine in hearts and eyes. The magic of the Holy Night has remained.

IN UPPER SWABIA

When on the tear-off calendar, which has already become noticeably thin, December appears for the first time, then thoughts of Christmas also emerge. And every time another candle is lit on the Advent wreath, the tension rises, the secrecies become even greater, and with them the anticipation of the most beautiful festival that exists for children's hearts. Already the Nicholas Market gives an idea of the splendor of the festival and the riot of color and abundance of gifts.

Especially the rocking horses and the dolls of all sizes stand out among everything else. In the coming weeks, the shop windows of the businesses shine in the glow of lights that are reflected in silver. Fir branches with angel hair and silver tinsel frame model trains, picture books, building sets, and the other treasures, and one does not wonder that these windows are besieged by a large crowd, and not just by children, especially in the evening hours. At home, the tempting scent of fresh baked goods wafts through the stairwell and in the evenings, when the little ones

are in bed, the grown-ups still have all kinds of work planned. Doll Gretel has lost her curly splendor, while the tail of the rocking horse has thinned out quite a bit and requires reinforcement. Late at night, when the boys and girls have long been dreaming of their greatest wishes and nuts and chocolate hearts, light still burns in the parlor.

One day the youngest discovers a fir tree in the laundry room. He cannot get to his siblings fast enough to tell them the find: "The Christmas tree is here." And after the few days of impatient waiting, it is finally time. It is Christmas Eve. All morning there is sweeping, dusting, and waxing again; in the kitchen, it sizzles and boils - for last week the eagerly fattened pig had to die - and after lunch, Father gets the Christmas tree stand and fits the tree in. With the participation of all, the tree is decorated and the children compete with each other, each wants to hang the most beautiful ball or the biggest bell. Again and again, a branch is discovered where a candle should actually go, and where a few threads of tinsel are still missing. Finally, the tree stands in full splendor on the table in the corner. The shutter there is closed, mysteriously it flashes and glitters from the semi-darkness, which is reinforced by the gloomy winter afternoon. Then the question falls from a child's mouth: "Papa, when are we going to the Christ Child?" "Soon," comes the answer, "dress nicely and warmly, then it will be just the right time." Meanwhile, it has started to snow very gently and slowly the twilight lays itself over the streets. Outside, people still hurry home individually, laden with a few packages. In an incredibly short time, the little ones stand, well-packed in coat, scarf, and wool cap before the Father: "Papa, we are ready. Are we going now?" They can no longer await it.

The closer one gets to the old Spital, the more frequently one meets fathers or mothers with their children, who all have the same goal: They want to greet the Christ Child when it comes down from heaven. There stands the dark mass of the buildings in the pale blanket of snow covering the street. Through a long corridor, one comes into the inner courtyard and at the end of the corridor stand large baskets, from which a sweet gingerbread is brought out for every child, the first Christmas treat. It has now become completely dark. The outlines of the large old buildings hardly stand out against the sky, from which snowflakes still float down very quietly and gently. No light is to be seen, only now and then a small beam steals out of a hallway. From somewhere out of the darkness, one hears violins tuning and the blowing of flutes and clarinets. Suddenly, in the middle of the black wall, a large transparency lights up: The Angel of the Lord steps among the frightened shepherds in the field and announces to them the great message of joy. And as the Choir of the Heavenly Legion rings out, the song "Oh Come, All Ye Faithful" can be heard, in which, down in the courtyard, first the adults, and after the first astonishment is overcome, the bright children's voices join in. While the old and yet eternally new "Silent Night, Holy Night" floats through the night, high above, surrounded by a radiant wreath of lights, appears the Christ Child, a wonderfully beautiful angel with blonde curly hair and a pure white, long dress embroidered with silver-stars. It comes lower and lower, and stops only just above the crowd of children, who believingly look upward. "Oh Come, Little Children" is the joyful call that goes out to everyone. All should come and marvel at the great miracle that has happened in this dark winter night. Slowly, as it came, the light-miracle ascends to

the sky, from where it had descended. In the courtyard it is as dark again as before. But in the children's eyes, it continues to shine, and completely under the spell of the great experience, everyone strives for home, for new surprises wait there. In the meantime the Christ Child 'was there and has spread its gifts under the Christmas tree. To welcome them Mother stands under the front door. "Mama, we saw the Christ Child." "Mama, was it at your place too?" "It was such a beautiful angel." With their hearts overflowing with joy and tension, the boys and girls storm towards her and tell the story. The cold feet and hands are completely forgotten. Mother, however, has provided for them; warm slippers stand ready. Then the parlor door opens. Captured anew by the glow of the candles and the glistening of the silver on the tree, they step closer in amazement and discover the gifts. Cheering breaks out. With beaming eyes, they show around what the Christ Child has bestowed them. Everything is duly admired and then the dear, old songs sound before the tree of lights, the same which Father and Mother had already sung when they had sat between their horses and dolls under the tree.

The rest of the evening passes under renewed admiration. The new train set is tested and the dolls are baptized and assigned their places in the doll household. But, listen, what is that? The music has no end tonight. Before the window, some young musicians have set themselves up with their lantern bearers, and their violins, clarinets, and flutes sound through the silence of the night. Father invites them to come in for a small snack and after they have warmed their clammy fingers and instruments at the stove, they move on, for they want to make even more of their relatives and friends happy.

Meanwhile, the time has come for the musician to blow his instrument from the tower. Already one sees up there some lanterns swaying back and forth and again the known melodies ring out to the night sky, and they end with the tender sounds of the ancient Pastoral, which, written by an unknown hand, has been passed down from year to year and from generation to generation.

That was the sign for the children to go to bed. They are indeed very tired, for they are never allowed to stay up so long. With their favorite gift in their arm, they dream into a magnificent Christmas morning full of radiant sun and shining blueness.

IN THURINGIA

DEDICATED TO THE MEMORY OF THE BEST GRANDPARENTS

Christmas! The word fades away. Christmas! I listen for the sound. Should it mean nothing to me anymore? Yet, listen! Deep in the heart, it begins to sing and ring, and old memories emerge vividly before my mind's eye.

Comrades, friends! Let me be a happy child once more, who can pray to the dear God with a pure heart.

Thoughts rush back a long, long time, years? No, decades. In our old, intimate residential city of Weimar, the gas lanterns are still burning, covered with a thick, white cap of snow. The narrow streets and narrow sidewalks are cushioned with a hard-packed layer of snow, and only the two black-drawn rail lines of the streetcar interrupt this soothing picture. The fountain at the Frauenplan, opposite the Goethe House, as well as the Neptune Fountain at the market, have also covered their winter protection with shining snow crystals. The Sea God, however, seems not at

all to agree with this element so strangely transformed for him, for he stretches his trident threateningly into the deep and gray-curtained sky, as if he wanted to ward off Frau Holle from letting more little snowflakes float to earth.

The sellers of Christmas trees at the market look anxiously at the sky. Should there be even more snow, after really enough has fallen this year already?

"Yes, this little tree costs five groschen." A boy, at the side of a haggard woman, takes overjoyed the fir tree, albeit very small and modest, onto his shoulder; for him, it is certainly more precious than a large tree for many a rich child. The mother had to work hard for these fifty pfennigs and postponed many an urgent expense. This poor boy is not attracted by the wonderfully smooth and flashing blades of the ice skates, on which boys and girls glide along like lightning, one behind the other without any care.

In the afternoon hours of the long-awaited Holy Eve, everything is so completely different than usual; one could almost say, everything seems mysteriously transformed. Solemn jingling bells sound from farmers' sleighs, which hurry to their farms after selling their heavy Christmas geese and completing many Christmas purchases; the steps of people are hardly to be heard, they whisk like on mighty carpets from shop to shop, now and then to stop for a moment before one of the so precious and temptingly decorated shop windows; yes, even the "evil" cars do not want to disturb the peace of the happy citizens today and roll towards their destination with a teasing "clink, clink" of their snow chains.

The hours, which in the weeks before did not want to pass at all, fly by in an instant. Twilight spreads its gray veils over the dreamy alleys with their precious secrets and hot expectations.

A happy flock of children comes with sleds and little carts out of the park; the old clock from the Castle Tower gave a warning. Oh, was that beautiful! The chatter on the stretches of path where one cannot drive is funny, and ice skaters stride proudly beside their sledding comrades. They dared today to rush down the long, now icy sledding tracks in a rapid ride on the narrow steel ribbons of their ice skates, so that the mouths of the drivers struggling upwards stayed open in astonishment. But everything went well today; only one sled did not get through the gate properly, which is formed by two trees, and out of the wildly dusting snow cloud rose laughing "Snow Dwarfs". The sled, of course, had to pay for the clumsiness with a brokenskid.

Now I just catch the particularly short descent at the house of Frau von Stein and then home! On the stairs, suit and sled are vigorously cleaned. Quietly I open the front door and sneak secretly, like Winnetou, to the parlor door to see if the Christmas tree is already there. Nothing? I don't understand that. With clear eyes, red cheeks, and a wolf's hunger, the parlor is now stormed. Hm, that smells good. "Grandma, are there raw dumplings tomorrow? Grandma, was the Christ Child not here yet to bring our Christmas tree? Grandma, Grandma....?" So it babbles merrily and eagerly during the meal, which tastes especially good after the romping around. And how fine it smells of roast, baked goods, sugar, and chocolate. Grandfather admonishes: "Boy, let Grandmother go, she still has to prepare the roast and I have to get ready for church. You too must still change, and quickly, it is already striking half past four."

"Yes, Grandpa, I'll be ready very quickly, and then we can go."

Muffled and wrapped up like a little Santa Claus, I leave the house with my grandparents as the bells of the Castle Tower call for the service. Into the solemn sounding of these bells chime those of the venerable Herder Church and the plain and simple Garrison Church. Together they fill the air with their rejoicing.

We go into the Castle Church. Actually, it is more of a chapel. Grand Duke Karl August, Goethe, Schiller, Franz Liszt, Wieland, and many others from the great wreath of poets and thinkers have been here to hear plain Bible words and to listen to Johann Sebastian Bach's mighty works, who was Court Organist in this church back then. I do not yet know what these names mean for Weimar and Germany, but I rejoice all the more in the two lit Christmas trees that immediately catch my eye as we enter the magnificent church. Today only the small "Hornngemeinde" is gathered and all adults and children are known to each other. The organ begins to raise its mighty voice; it plays the Christmas carol that addressed ourselves: "Oh Come, Little Children". We are allowed to sing along and happily and vigorously I join in, for I know all the verses by heart.

Grandfather does not quite know what to do, for his voice is already coarse and deep; finally, he sings along after all. Then comes our pastor, whom we like to hear. He preaches of Christmas. But what Grandma told me about the Christ Child, I understood much better. However, he certainly means well, and we are silent, so as to listen particularly well at the passages that are known to us. Is that not the Christ Child singing with the angel-like voice? Wonderfully tender, clear, and deeply moving, organ, choir, and female soloist join together in the song: "How a Rose E'er Blooming". I like that, it is so beautiful. I recognize the song of the Silent Night and sing along eagerly. After that, it becomes quite still in the church. "Let us pray." I stand up with my grandparents, who are probably praying for me now. "Dear God, I love my grandparents very much and also the Christ Child, who will bring us so many beautiful things afterwards. Please, let the grandparents always be quite happy and let me be quite good to them." My prayer ends with the Amen of the pastor and the congregation. Now we sing the Christmas carol: "Oh du fröhliche..." and with the fading organ tones, we leave the church. I am allowed to carry a little booklet that we received at the exit. It shows a wonderful deer with a magnificent sled and the most darling Christ Child. It is loaded with sacks, packages, and bags with many, many gifts. Will I perhaps see the Christ Child? For we are going to Aunt Marta and Uncle Erich and Santa Claus comes there every year to give us gifts. The streets have become empty of people. The happy churchgoers hurry to their cozy warm parlors filled with joyful secrets. A lonely Pretzel man stands at the corner of the Marstall and offers in his basket still crispy baked goods for sale. Not much longer, then he goes home too, to celebrate Christmas. Now and then we show each other the Christmas trees that cast their radiant light through the windows. Now we are finally there. My heart beats fast thinking of the next minutes, for which I have longed for weeks and of which I yesterday sang with my playmates: Tomorrow, children, there will be something.

Everyone is already gathered and the parlor is full of uncles and aunts. Even our shepherd dog Prinz is allowed to be in the parlor with us today when Santa Claus comes. Ursel, Elfriede, Heinz, and Alfred have already taken possession of the best

places at the Christmas tree and nibble eagerly on the gingerbread and cookies that were bought at the Nicholas Market. I, the biggest and strongest, make use of my right as chief of the play community. Soon, however, everything going on around us is forgotten, for we are too busy with the many questions of what Santa Claus will bring us. There, listen! Heavy steps stomp up the stairs and stop before our corridor door. It knocks quite loudly. Aunt Linda hurries quickly to open up. Like the storm wind, each of us children has rushed to the one he likes best, and from whom he hopes for the most protection. I hold the hands of dear Grandmother convulsively tight and look at the door, which now opens... It is Santa Claus. Attired in a thick, brown fur coat, the face framed by a long white beard and with a large red wool cap on his head, he looks around in the room which is quiet as a mouse; he probably wants to see if we are all there? On his broad back, he carries a mightily large sack and in his hand a package. Out of the coat pocket peeks a Jumping Jack, merry and at the same time comforting into the room, as if he wanted to take away our fear of Santa Claus, who unfortunately holds a large cane in his hand. "From outside, from the woods I come..." It is good that Santa Claus himself says that in our city there are "only purely good children". Oh, but then he asks if we were all well-behaved. Grandmother answers him, for we do not yet dare to say anything: "Yes, dear Santa Claus, the children were always very well-behaved and good." "Well, then it is good, but where is Helmut?" My courage, so great yesterday, has completely vanished, and only Grandmother's hands holding me tight prevent me from seeking refuge behind her. "Can you also pray?" Now I recite the prayer that Aunt Marta taught us for Santa Claus. Quite correctly, albeit rather haltingly, I pray:

"Dear, good Santa Claus, do not look at me so angrily, put away your cane, for I want to always be good."

"Yes, that was good, and now I must ask Elfriede if she can pray too." She can too. Only Little Gisela, who has climbed into her mother's arms and hastily prattles the words spoken to her: "Dear, good Santa Claus, do not look at me so angrily, put away your cane" starts to cry here, so that Santa Claus has to comfort her. Ha, how Gisela laughs then, with a face still streaming with tears, when Santa Claus gives her the funny Punch puppet and she holds this brave fellow in her little arms. Oh, fine, Aunt Irma gets a beating with the cane because she cannot pray. I think she is even laughing. But no, she cries and quickly hides her face shamefacedly behind her hands. "But now you must still sing a song, before the gifts of the Christ Child can be distributed."

"We all know our beautiful song that we already sang in church today: 'Oh Come, Little Children...'" Although only Uncle Werner accompanies it with the zither, it goes well, since the aunts and uncle sing along too. "Because you sang so well, I want to give out gifts right away." Look, what all is in the bag! Each of us gets so much that proper mountains pile up. But now the blessing seems to be at an end. We have reconciled with Santa Claus and it is actually a pity that he already wants to leave. "So, now I have given you children everything the Christ Child had for you. Finally, however, I must still give a gift to Grandma, for she has received three colorful oilcloth tablecloths, one each from Grandpa, Werner, and Helmut. You have truly good children, Grandma." Who is happier now, we, who were allowed to give a gift

to the one who usually always gives, or she, who leans back quite quietly in her upholstered chair with joy and lets her good, soulful eyes wander again and again through the room, in which happiness, peace, and contentment prevail, over the large flock of her children and grandchildren. "Now I must go, for many good children are still waiting for me." When Santa Claus is at the door, he takes the now-light bag off his back again and pours the whole remainder with a mighty swing into the surprised room. They are the best nuts of all kinds, which cunningly hide under the sofa, the cupboards, tables, and chairs. "Whoever finds the golden nut may dream quite beautifully of the Christ Child tonight." Now the plagued Santa Claus is out of the room and with lightning speed we excited children are crawling on all fours on the floor to pick up the nuts, to collect them in the prepared bowls and paper plates, but above all, to search for the golden nut. Quite in a secret corner, where we "big ones" cannot go at all, Gisela finds this coveted treasure and holds it out jubilantly and happily to Uncle Erich, who has meanwhile entered the room: "Uncle Erich, Uncle Erich, I am allowed to dream of the Christ Child." Is it evil envy or did Heinz notice something? "Uncle Erich, Santa Claus had the same trousers on as you. Where were you so long?" The uncle has to tell how he waited on the street to perhaps be able to bring the hurrying Christ Child into our room. "Did you see the Christ Child?" "Yes, but it had to go to the poor children who lie sick in bed and cannot jump around like you." That is nice of the Christ Child and we think for a few moments of neighbor's Hans, who lay in the hospital for a long time with pneumonia and is now home with his mother, but may not get up. While the bells call again to the church service, mostly only to those people who remained without the blessing of children, or whose children are grown up, the large table is festively set for the meal. We must leave our many gifts, which we have not even been able to look at properly yet. But I put a beautiful gear wheel from my Maerklin construction kit into my pocket with many other things, to perhaps be able to look at it during the meal. Blue Carp [Karpfen blau] is served and we gladly let the beautiful pieces of fish be placed on our plates, which, carefully freed from fish bones and poured over with fatty sauce, taste magnificent. As usual, no real conversation arises, for the contemplatively burning wax candles in the holders on the table, plus the upward-striving lights of the Christmas tree, make everything so solemn, but we can feel it more than say it and behave accordingly. Finally, we children are allowed to get up and rush to our gifts. Now the time has come to compare, to envy, or even to swap. Alfred takes Elfriede's doll and gives her his wooden horse with wagon. After a short time, this exchange is remorsefully reversed. Oh, what is there not to admire. Only a pity that the aunts, who can marvel at everything so beautifully, have no technical understanding. Aunt Erna understands absolutely nothing about the windmill that I want to build, and only Uncle Werner can fasten the windmill blades to the shaft so that they also move when I turn the crank. Gisela, in her left arm her colorful Punch puppet and the new wonderful Mama-doll, which closes its blue eyes when laid down, feeds with her right hand Prinz, the dog, with cookies. Our Prinz gladly puts up with that. With a clever face and pricked ears, so that he understands everything his little mistress wants from him, he sits there, magnificent to look at, and also knows how to behave when he is allowed to take "only a little bit". Carefully he lifts his lips and even more

carefully he places his blindingly white teeth on the only millimeter-large piece of cookie that is released by the fingers, and so he breaks off this little piece to consume it with the greatest pleasure. This game repeats itself several times and Gissi is overjoyed; she would like to give her Prinz a kiss. But she is not allowed to do that, but she is allowed to love him really properly and press his warm neck against her beaming face, and does it quite enthusiastically and with a heart overflowing from all the beautiful experiences today.

The many candles of the Christmas tree are lit once again, which we are allowed to do by letting ourselves be lifted up. Then there is again the solemn silence in the room, until Uncle Werner plays the eternally old and always young Christmas carols and we sing along. "Silent Night..." remains always the most beautiful. Grandfather, who sits close to the comfortable tiled stove, holds the little hands of Alfred, who has squeezed himself between his legs, in his old, wrinkled, and work-worn hands. He had lost the middle, ring, and little finger of his right hand when using the circular saw. It was a hard time back then. The blood poisoning that set in let the anxious grandmother spend many a tearful night at the bed of her feverish and moaning husband, but then everything turned out well and additionally to the five siblings growing up then, seven more came. They have all become healthy, upright, and industrious people, whose magnificent children in this consecrated hour place themselves again near the white-haired grandparents in the honorable ancestral line of an old Thuringian peasant lineage. The spicy scent of the noble fir mixes with the full fragrant and oily scent of the wax. We children sing Christmas carol after Christmas carol in solemn devotion. By the flickering and crackling of the burnt fir needles, the candles announce that they have used themselves up in Christ Child's honor.

The spicy coffee scent that penetrates to us from the kitchen warns us not to nibble too much on the sugary things, for there is still fresh-baked cake and then we will go to the "Christmas Tree for Everyone". How good tastes the white-powdered "Schittchen", which the others call Christmas Stollen. Aunt Marta can bake them especially well. Yes, for Ursel and me there is even Poppy Seed Cake (Mohnkuchen), which we love to eat. But we don't have much hunger left today. As we get up to get dressed, I stick a few pieces of chocolate in my pocket - for the way.

Meanwhile, it has become dark night and a star-studded sky chimes in with the jubilation that lives in us, despite the parting from our gifts. We have only a few steps to make across the Rollplatz, and there we already see at the Museum the mighty Christmas tree shining in full blaze of lights. It gives its light to all, the poor and rich, the sick and healthy, the small and big, the locals and strangers. On the Bornberg, the old, small houses snuggle close together, for they see so much shining splendor only once every year. Now we stand a few meters away from the tree and marveling we look up to this proud giant, who lifts his radiantly shining cross almost up to the blinking and twinkling starry sky. Fourteen meters high is the tree, which is decorated with burning little lights, a Christmas joy to all. Now the bells of the city begin to ring in a many-voiced choir; the bells of the Catholic church also join in the rejoicing, calling, and admonishing of their Protestant sisters. On the wide stairs of the mildly illuminated Museum, the Choir of the National Theater and

the Lay Brass Choir of the City Church are positioned. The last tones of the bells fading over the listening city take up the song: "Come, ye shepherds, ye men and women..." The aged City Pastor knows of the silent distress that prevails among his congregation. But he also knows of the good will to alleviate this distress and the tables fill up visibly with gifts of varied kinds for the poor, which on Sunday morning are meant to be especially bestowed. I also am allowed to add a thick picture book and one of the three oilcloth tablecloths. Do I already know what it means to give and to cause joy? I think so, for I too have saved penny after penny in the days before the festival, in order to be able to buy Grandmother the carefully chosen oilcloth and other small gifts, and Grandfather a box of thick cigars. It was only good that the knowing Uncles gave me many small errands and thus even more pennies. Meanwhile, the Brass Choir plays a wonderfully beautiful chorale, which echoes far into the city, and despite the considerable cold, the windows open in the large round of snow-covered houses, and like a thousand small lovely mirror images, one sees everywhere the Christmas trees standing out in the semi-dark parlors. This reminds me whether Santa Claus or the Christ Child have brought a fir tree to my home after all. The song of the Silent Night lets the simple celebration fade away and the muffled crowd disperses in a festive mood.

It is quite dark in our alley, for the wind has blown out the lantern of our house. I keep myself well between Grandfather and Uncle Werner, since the always helpful Grandmother stayed with the Aunt. Why am I afraid? I do not know. It is actually no fear at all, it is just so completely different than usual. The front door is soon opened and then also the parlor door. Bright light breaks towards me out of the cozy parlor and joyfully jubilating I rush to the decorated tree, for this is my tree, it belongs to me all alone, next to the happy grandparents of course. There are also the old familiar friends who decorate this tree of lights so particularly lovably: The meter-long white pearl chain, which swings merrily in a gentle arc from branch to branch, as if hugging the tree, then the glass icicles, which sound so magical when they clink together. Deeper in the branches, shy mushrooms with their white feet and red heads have hidden themselves. Every single one of the glass balls is known and familiar to me. The red one over there has a new wire hook; the silver one, in which a colorful world of colors is reflected in a magic nest, I bought with Grandmother from a poor wandering peddler and glassblower from the Thuringian Forest, who also left the four snow-covered little bells, which now hang on the uppermost branches, each under a candle. I wonder whether they still chime as beautifully as last year? I am lifted up by Uncle Werner and allowed to hear them: That is like Angel Music or perhaps like the music at the wedding feast of the beautiful Dwarf Princess in the often-heard fairy tale. And above everything shines the mighty silver star, which probably looks most similar to the one from Bethlehem. Between all this delicious decoration hang fine silver threads in glittering, flashing variety, and over everything a tender veil of gossamer-thin Angel Hair is spread, as if it wanted to protect from unauthorized access this precious treasure of tree decorations and the artistic little birds of multi-colored glass sitting on the branches. As Uncle Werner puts me back on the floor, I must also admire the rich gift table of the grandparents, which stands under the Christmas tree. A vast amount of gifts proves how much the big and small children feel what they owe to this unique pair of

parents and how much more they would gladly like to do. But there is no need for that, and Grandfather's protests: "Why do you buy so much" is probably just a pretext to hide the inner grateful emotion. Grandmother is unable to say anything again. Her tears of joy and the old woman's hand, gratefully blessing us, speak more than words. But I also experience once again a great joy. Blossom-white, yet carefully warm and enviably beautiful lies a turtleneck sweater with matching scarf and cap there, all crocheted and knitted by the untiring Grandmother herself in late evening hours. That is a new elation and I have to be admonished smilingly to rest, for it has already become very late. Now I must go into the waiting bed. That goes quickly. Once again I said Good Night and Thanks to everyone, then wistfully took leave of all gifts for a few hours and went into the cold bedroom. In the soft bed lies the hot water bottle, and as I crawl under the blanket, I notice that the worried Grandfather has already moved the hot water bottle from place to place several times, so that everything is quite nicely warm and "the boy" does not freeze in the Holy Night.

As always, the good-hearted Grandmother comes, once more to me. I was alone only a few minutes and therefore now the anxious question: "Grandma, may I also dream of the Christ Child?" Her simple answer: "You must only pray for it quite nicely" shows me the right way: "Dear God, please let me also dream of the Christ Child, even if I did not find the golden nut, and please, love the Grandparents, Parents, Brother, and all people as much as I do. Amen." Quietly I look at the silent Grandmother afterwards and see my little hands in her hands, which I have looked at so often and marveled at again and again, how beautiful they are. No, that is not right, she has loving, good, soulful Mother hands, such as I rarely saw. I fall asleep and dream. --

Of what? I don't know anymore. Perhaps of the Christ Child, perhaps of Prinz [the dog] and Gissi, perhaps of Uncle Karl, who fell in the World War, and for whom Grandmother cries so much, or perhaps of the longed-for time that I always picture to myself: That I am grown up and rich and can give the venerable grandparents a blooming garden with many flowers and a cozy home, where they can then live with me, my happy wife, and my many healthy children and tell these of their eternalized parents and grandparents, as it was now so often with me.

Peace on Earth

Dec 24

1945 - 195[2?]

AT THE SEASIDE

Accompanied by the full tones of the organ, the jointly sung Christmas carol fades away, and joyfully tuned, we schoolboys leave the auditorium of the High School, which is festively decorated with fir-tree green. The holidays have finally begun. Slowly we stroll through the streets, which are slushy from the wet snow. Again and again, our gaze is caught by the shop windows, which praise the most beautiful gifts for the upcoming Christmas festival, rich and full of splendor. We marvel at the infinite abundance of the department stores, where huge Santa Clauses give the whole thing a timely character. The toy department is a special attraction. With

pounding hearts, the children stand here holding their parents' hands. They follow the tirelessly circulating electric train, inspect the proud fortresses with countless soldiers, hear the dolls call "Mama" in astonishment, and delight enthusiastically in the other toys that can be seen in this dreamland. The parents can hardly fend off the assault of their little ones. They are constantly pulled to new things, and the wish list would have to be infinite if everything were written down that the enthusiastic boys and girls claim for their gift table.

But this time the holidays - there are only a few days left until the festival - must be used to finish the Christmas work started long ago. So I am soon secretly behind a locked door, making a gift for my parents and my brother. Only the screeching of the coping saw betrays that I am working. I must also not forget to memorize my lines of the Christmas poem. What would my mother say if I could only stammer them out at the next rehearsal.

In the evening, I go to the Nativity Play performed by the schoolchildren. On the way there, I have to squeeze through the overcrowded streets, where many people hurry from shop to shop to buy for Christmas. One does not perceive the darkness, although it has long since fallen. Countless rows of electric bulbs are stretched over the main shopping streets and make everything as bright as day. Large fir trees are set up in the squares, whose sea of lights illuminates the surrounding houses.

Almost at all street corners stand musicians with hand organs, timpani, violins, trumpets, singing saws, and other wonderful instruments, delighted about every penny that falls into their caps. From afar sounds the hustle and bustle of the Christmas market, whose colorful lights rise above the roofs of the city. The music of the carousels and the shouting of the showmen, who invite the enterprising public to look at the wonders of the world, ring in our ears.

But I steer my steps further, into not so heavily populated, dark alleys, until I stand before the church towering into the night. Slowly I open the heavy door to take my seat in silence. And then I see once again our magnificent Nativity Play in Low German language. I almost know it by heart, have participated myself in other years, and always I delight again in the freshness and earthiness of this play. They all come to look at the little Christ Child and to offer gifts: The Old Shepherd with Fiete and the other young shepherds, the three kings, one of whom has painted his face pitch black, the evil Innkeepers and the hard, merciless landlady with her husband, who could not bear to see Mary and Joseph standing outside in the cold night, and finally offered them shelter in the stable.

With the feeling of having had a wonderful pre-Christmas day, I go home. Before I go to bed, however, I do not forget to put my slipper in front of the window. My younger brother is already asleep, but I notice that he has also placed his shoe in a conspicuous place on the windowsill. And it is he, too, who wakes me early in the morning and shows me, what St. Nicholas has put in his shoe. A small piece of "Lübeck Marzipan". In mine, I find a bar of chocolate, a better sign than a cane. My mother has been up for a long time; she has much planned for today. It is necessary to finish the remaining preparations for the festivity, of whose fullness we children cannot form a proper picture, since we suspect the work of Santa Claus behind them. We are allowed to help Mother with the baking, and it happens quite often that some of the delicious brown dough is secretly stuffed into our mouths.

When Father comes home from business in the evening, we ask to be allowed to help decorate the tree. Smiling, he grants it. We fetch the many boxes with the decorations and the stand, and then the green fir tree, carefully chosen at the tree market, is transformed into a smart Christmas tree. Christmas baubles, tinsel, angel hair, stars, gilded nuts, and many other things are fixed on the tree. How it will shine under its many candles! But until then we still have to be patient. Going to bed happily, however, we are already allowed to sing:

"Once more we will wake up,
heissa, then it is Christmas Day."

On the morning of the twenty-fourth of December, we open the last window of our Christmas calendar. The day of the greatest tension is imminent. The door to the parlor, the Christmas room, is locked. I dare a curious glance trying to find out what I will receive in the evening. But they probably foresaw it, for the hole is clogged wrapping paper for oranges. Particularly today the hours pass much too slowly. Again and again, I look at the clock, but the hand of the clock seems to stand still. When we have finally put on our Sunday suits in the late afternoon, darkness slowly falls, the tension knows no bounds.

After the family's joint churchgoing, the much anticipated moment has arrived. The door opens. Speechless and amazed, we enter the Christmas room, while with the chiming of bells the song of the fir tree sounds softly. Before us stands, towering over everything, the fir tree in full blaze of lights. The whole family gathers devoutly before it and sings under the flickering of the many candles: "O Christmas Tree, O Christmas Tree..." Then I step forward and play a long-practiced Christmas carol on the flute. After this, I recite my Christmas poem. My brother, barely started school, must also recite a poem before the tree, which he performs splendidly today despite all difficulties in practicing. The parents are very pleased about it, and we are allowed to rush to our gifts.

Everyone knows their gift table under the fir tree, where many beautiful things are set up. Already during the singing, many a furtive glance drifted there. But before I look closely at my gifts, I hurry out to fetch my handcrafted gifts from a hiding place, which I then hand over to my parents, joyfully moved. The gratitude for the many gifts is great everywhere. This year, too, Santa Claus was very diligent. I go from one gift table to the other and rejoice over all the precious gifts. Meanwhile, my brother has already covered the entire floor with his toys. Thus the first hours of Christmas Eve go by, during which we eagerly eat from the colorful paper plates with nuts and sweets.

Then Mother calls for the feast. She has meanwhile set the table magnificently with her best dinnerware. Next to the fir tree, the Advent crown, now with its four lights, also provides a cozy light. From steaming bowls, Carp and beautiful yellow potatoes with tasty butter sauce are served. The wine -- for us boys apple cider -- is filled into sparkling glasses. It never tastes as good as exactly today. Hardly is the meal finished when the doorbell rings. The neighbor boys appear and tell excitedly how the festivity was at their place and gifts they received. They marvel at our gift tables, to subsequently take us along and show us their new toys. We do not notice that it already is midnight. Even if we boys are allowed to stay up longer today than otherwise in the whole year, we unfortunately have to go to bed now. Everyone

quickly grabs a favorite gift, which he takes to bed with him, and soon the eyes close for quiet, peaceful sleep.

By the chiming of the bells of all the venerable churches of the city, we are awakened on the First Christmas Day. The morning passes with the visits of the neighbors, who all come to wish a merry Christmas, while we boys meet outside on the toboggan run to use the snow that fell in the night. After a magnificent lunch -- there is a stuffed Christmas goose -- the whole family goes to the City Theater to watch the Christmas Fairy Tale. Merrily the scenes of a Grimm's fairy tale, which is tailored to the stage, Christmas, and city conditions, pass us by. In the evening, the tree of lights is lit again. We gather around it and sing the many beautiful Christmas carols that Mother taught us. Thereby we look back to the past year. And to our great regret, the festivity is now gradually drawing to its close, for the Second Christmas Day is already coming. Quietly we all enjoy the last hours of the festivity once more. The candles burn for the last time. And while they burn down slowly, everything is quiet. Only the Nutcracker cracks the nutshells loud with his giant mouth. Little by little the lights go out. Finally, Father gives the signal and we two boys run to the fir tree to pick sweets and red apples. With the glow of the sparklers, the festivity fades out, and we must go to bed. The next day the Christmas room is cleared. Only the tree remains standing until it too is plundered and burned after New Year, as the last sign of an unforgettably beautiful festivity.

IN A HANSEATIC CITY

Whoever entered my little hut in Kenedy - it lies in Texas and will be found on only a few maps, so insignificant is it to the great world - would have soon noticed in the unadorned interior a small, peculiar hanging ornament made of colorful spheres, disks, and cubes, held together by a gold thread. It hung in the middle of the corner shelf, just above the table where I sat during the day. No visitor ever asked me about its origin, purpose, or meaning, probably sensing that one must not stir at certain things. And when later, after the photographs taken away from us at our capture were returned, the picture of my Mother stood above it and one would have likely assumed a connection between the two. He guessed correctly: The hanging ornament and the Mother in the picture are connected by something. And what connects them is no secret, and certainly shall not be one to those who sit with me now in the Christmas circle.

It is November 1933. From the apartment, street, and district where I spent my childhood and youth, Mother and I move to another suburb of my hometown Lübeck. The move, we both feel, closes a significant chapter of life and is the beginning of a new one. The different room conditions and needs - I get my own room - force a rearrangement and reorganization of the furniture. There we discover that many a piece, many a picture had had its place in the room and on the wall only out of a dear old habit. Also, the taste of the times and probably our own has changed, so that some furnishings no longer correspond to our sense of beauty. Spontaneously, though not entirely without pain, we part from them. But soon we find an ever-growing joy in redesigning and reordering, so that, when everything now stands in its right place, our home feels given to us anew.

Quickly the dear Advent time has come. And when now the third Advent light burns

on the wreath, we set out to choose a fir tree. We both go, for neither likes to bear the responsibility alone; there is a special significance precisely with our tree. It must not be big, for it stands on the table. But our tree must be lithe and lissom, the branches must be set densely and evenly all around, as it turns in its stand. And our fir must smell fresh of dark resin and deep forest. The needles must be firm and juicy so that its dress can delight us straight into the new year.

When we want to decorate our Christmas tree, fetch the big Christmas box from the attic and open it, we realize very soon that over the course of twenty years, all sorts of glittery stuff, chains and colorful balls, all kinds of glass animals and glass bells that do not ring, many things from past childhood days have accumulated there, which, when we look at them no longer fit us and our Christmas room at all, and look at us now tiredly and a little sadly. We give them to the children outside, who happily let take them home and let them come to new brilliance.

And our tree? Straight and slender it stands there. No, we do not want to veil its beautiful shape again, not cover it with glittering threads; it shall delight us in its whole chaste beauty. We do not want to dress it with alien pomp, but certainly decorate it festively.

A few days before I discovered in an Alt-Angeln Weaving Workshop a peculiar tree decoration: Hanging ornaments made from colorful wooden spheres and cubes.

That would be the right thing for our tree; wooden decoration will suit it. But the few pieces I can purchase look far too pathetic. Then a thought comes to us. On the afternoon before Christmas Eve, we walk through the festively excited streets of the city and finally find, just as we are letting our courage sink, in a street away from the great bustle between old houses, in a small inconspicuous craft shop, what we had sought in vain in all the big stores: Beads, spheres of various sizes, also half ones, cubes, angular and round disks in blue, red, yellow, brown, and wood colors.

In the evening, we sit in our Advent corner on the sofa. The four lights on the Advent wreath above the round table shine festively. Fir branches show green out of the dark blue, paunchy Bunzlauer vases, which Father had been sent from there to be sold at the Lübeck Christmas Market. Firs also show green in the matte-brown noble-shaped clay vase that we bought only recently. Red and golden ribbons swing over the dark green. On the small bedside table stands the catkin vase. Two weeks ago I cut the catkins from the snow-covered hedgerow. Now, in the warmth of the room, they have stretched and scatter their yellow pollen onto the blue cloth. In a wooden bowl lie all sorts of good things: Nuts, figs, cookies and truffles, "cobblestones" (a kind of gingerbread) with sugar coating and on top honey cake with colorful sugar sprinkles. A marzipan loaf is also cut. Red wine punch glows in the glass and to celebrate the day, the cake, which smells freshly baked through the apartment, is also tasted.

I had almost forgotten the Star Chapel standing on the radio and greeting the festive time in four-voices guided by the moon.

But on the round table, on a white linen cloth, lie by the hundreds our beads and cubes, the spheres and disks, shining happily and enticing us to string them together into colorful hanging ornaments. I try to do it, but it is not to my satisfaction. So I watch Mother, how she chooses with sure taste, constantly changing color and form, looking for and finding ever new combinations and then pulling them onto

golden threads! How skillfully her hands deal with the little things, yes, these hands. How overworked they are, I have to think. How much good have they done to me in my life, these hands. They closed around me when I was small, led me, when I happily took the first steps into the big world. They washed and dressed me, they fed me until I could hold the spoon myself. They prepared the little bed for me in the evening and then stroked my head gently if I did not want to sleep right away and also probably late in the evening, when I already lay deep in sleep. The dear, good Mother-hands. They bandaged the many small wounds that the wild boy struck himself, and healed caressingly, soothing the pain. They probably punished me sometimes too, but I don't know it anymore, so rarely did they do it, not because it wouldn't have been necessary, no, because it was too hard for them. And if the hand really hit me once, then it certainly pained her more than me. And it is also certain that these hands in the next hour secretly made up for the pain many times over. Also, the hands played the piano and plucked the lute. **But then the war came!** One day, it was also around Christmas time, these tireless hands lay powerless in the lap, wet with tears. I felt quite fearful. But then these hands began to live again and to stir. They washed, scrubbed, and shied away from absolutely no work, even if this was formerly done by other hands. They tailored, knitted, and embroidered, not just as before for leisure, but for daily bread and to be able to give joy to the boy from the earnings. Only rarely did they have time to hold a book in a leisure hour. And as the years passed, they often stroked me understandingly over the forehead and hair, quite softly. Again the hands healed wounds and pains, only that now they were not on arms and legs, but in the heart and in the soul. How often have they probably folded for me in prayer, these dear, overworked hands. But suddenly there are no more balls and disks on the table. About fifty hanging ornaments lie on the table. Mother strings them on a knitting needle and lets them dangle merrily. It is time, we can decorate our tree.

Carefully I wind up the work in the stand for the tree, which is also a musical box and has been working at Christmas time for half a century now, without tiring or taking serious damage. When I release the spring, a trembling goes through the tree right up to the top. Hesitantly, as if it could not grasp the miracle happening to it, it spins at first haltingly, until it then fully comprehends its new freedom and then turns steadily and willingly. It holds out its branches to us, which we now decorate in passing, until every tip carries its hanging ornament and our hands are empty. With dark red apples we weigh down the branches in the tree's interior. Now they stretch out in their full width. We place on the branches honey soaked candles drawn from good beeswax. Thus everything has remained genuine and natural on it, our fir tree from the German winter forest.

We cover a dark green cloth, that falls far over the table edges, over the shiny metal housing that carries the mechanism within itself,. Since the green now looks like a good pasture, I let cows and calves, horses and sheep and also the curious donkey out of the splint box. It's been a long time since I opened the lid. One of the two donkeys naturally discovers the crib immediately, which stands under the fir, and looks amazed at the little Child in it. Mary and Joseph allow it gently and good-naturedly. My old schoolmate Ludwig Krock sawed and painted them for me for a past Christmas.

The tree doesn't spin anymore. It rests and dreams towards Christmas Eve. Quietly we extinguish the last lamp.

Now it is time. While I listen to the Christmas story in the shadow of a pillar, leaning into the old pews of the Cathedral, Mother starts the last preparations. It has become dark and quiet in the streets when I go home. Behind the windows muffled light shimmers, candlelight on Christmas trees. At home we eat, remove the dishes together, spread out the gifts on the large round of the table in the Christmas room, all wrapped in varied and colorful Christmas paper.

The great hour of our tree is here. With grace it wears its decoration, as if it had never been otherwise. Mother lies on the sofa so that she can see it. Now it spins and one candle after the other is lit. The glow warmly fills the whole room. Then the stand reveals its second secret. From its interior, it sounds soft and clear: "Silent Night, Holy Night!" and then "Oh Come, Little Children, oh come all ...". The music box of "Dear Augustin" could not have sounded more intimate and heart-touching. Many dear memories awaken in these sounds, until they are lost. Quietly the tree spins again.

On the flute I play the dear old and new Christmas tunes, I read and sing of the angels who brought the glad tidings, the shepherds who heard them and ran to the stable; of Mary who sings a little song to her Child, the Wonder Flower, which blooms in the midst of ice and snow, the dear nightingales which woke up from all the jubilation and began to sing. I sing of the many candles, which burn on the trees everywhere in this high night of clear stars.

And then I let it fade out with the lines that say and mean so much:

Mothers, for you all fires,
all candles are set up,
Mothers, deep in your hearts
beats the heart of the wide world.

I nod to my little Mother. She understands what I want to say. Then we exchange gifts. It has become late doing so. The tree has stopped its wandering. It considers all the miracles of which it heard and saw.

The days between Christmas and New Year pass quickly. Often we are invited to dear acquaintances. When we then come home in the evening and sit for another quarter of an hour in our Christmas corner and look at our tree, then we realize again and again: No Christmas tree equals ours. Surely we have the most beautiful and strange one in the whole city. And when our little tree hears that, then it stretches and one notices, how proud it is of its decoration.

New Year's Eve the lights are lit for the last time. Mother lies on the sofa and I have made myself comfortable in the Christmas corner. We speak of the past year, what it promised and what it kept, and we speak also of the future. Again the tree circles around its star at the top. The lights diminish and drip away. Here one flares up and extinguishes suddenly. There a flame sinks more and more into itself, becomes small and smaller and finally burns out imperceptibly. Slower turns our tree, needles fall off. The dialogue between Mother and her boy becomes slower and quieter and also deeper the thoughts.

And even in passing away, light and tree reveal a miracle to us in their interplay.

The last lights cast weak branch shadows on the ceiling. They are still outshone by the brightness in the room. Again a light goes out, the shadow images now stand out more clearly. They become sharper and darken more and more. They remain probably unchanged in themselves, but shift against each other, until then again a new candle has evaporated and the remaining ones cast new shadow images on the ceiling. Now only one is burning. The ceiling is spanned by a mighty shadowed arbor. When, in the last tired turn, a twig grazes the curtain, hooks itself fast, but then releases it after all, it is as if a sudden gust of wind brings the shadowed arbor into motion. A hanging ornament stands out, spheres, disks, rings, and cubes. It hangs in the lit space, close above the last flame, which now slowly sinks into itself, flares up once more and extinguishes.

It is dark in the room. Since we have been silent for a long time, only the soft ticking of the clock can be heard. Christmas is over.

We take the decorations off the tree and put them in the Christmas box, piece by piece. "God grant that we can decorate our little tree again next Christmas, healthy and happy together," says my Mom.

Year after year passes, and Mother's wish is always fulfilled; I am at home even in the first four Christmases during WWI. All sorts of new light-bearers were added. They came from the German Christmas land, the Erzgebirge; but neither the light-bearing angels and miners, nor the light arch or the pyramid, whose wings turn in the rising heat of the candles, nor the "Christmas Spider", a chandelier with many light arms, nor the incense smoker can displace or even replace our Christmas tree. It stands elevated in the center of the Christmas event.

But in October of the war year 1943, I know for certain that I will not be home for Christmas. I let Mother know. So in the first week of November she sends me a small package through a soldier on leave. It is intended for Christmas, wrapped in fir-green paper and tied with wide gold ribbons. On an attached note, I read: To be opened only on Christmas!

And now it is here once again, the Holy Eve. The Commander and I drive out to our soldiers on the lonely base on the Atlantic, giving and receiving much Christmas joy. We sit with them under the trees of lights in the bunkers and speak again and again of home. Where else could our thoughts be in this hour?

Only late in the evening do we sit in the Christmas room of the chateau, where we are housed, and read the letters from our loved ones. "You are coming soon," Mother jubilates, "I am already counting the days." When midnight is past, I find a good reason to go up to my room, where Mother's package waits. In the shine of a burning candle, I slowly loosen the knots and ribbons, unfold the paper. I do not yet suspect what the package contains. I lift the lid and fold back the fragrant tissue paper. There it lies, a small Soldier's Christmas Tree with green, lightly snow-covered branches. And underneath it shines yellow and red and blue - small cubes and disks and spheres threaded on gold threads, tiniest replicas of the familiar Christmas tree decorations. Every piece, into which I know a loving wish and thought is woven, I hold in my hand for a moment as I now quietly decorate my little Christmas tree. Ten years lie between today and the day when Mother's hands first put them together, the dear, dear Mother-hands. There are twenty-four small works of art, one for each branch; only the top of the tree bears none. For a long time, I

am at home with my thoughts. The last glance, as I extinguish the candle, falls on the little tree.

At the turn of the year, I travel to Mother and take my little tree with me. I know, indeed, that she could not bring herself to decorate the big tree alone.

So this time the little Soldier's Christmas Tree represents the big brother from the forest and yet means just as much, even if it cannot turn. It is proud, like the big one, of its colorful decoration. But Mother asks about the hanging ornament for the tip of the little tree. "Twenty-five, not twenty-four it must be," Mother thinks. Well, it will still lie in the box that I left behind in the chateau.

When I look for it after my leave, I do not find it. What does it matter. Christmas and leave are over and there are now other and more important things to consider.

Spring comes and goes, then the decisive hour breaks for the front on the Atlantic. From the Channel coast, the thunder rolls over to us, who suspect the fateful significance of this confrontation. The hour strikes for us too, in which we arm ourselves for battle. While hurriedly packing the bare necessities, the tissue paper in which my Christmas tree was wrapped comes into my hand. As I throw it into the flickering fireplace fire, a colorful thing falls out of it towards me - the lost hanging ornament for the top of my little tree. I hold it in my hands, the small inconspicuous something. It is to me as if Mother herself had put it in there, as if she said, "Take it with you, my boy. It shall be a sign to you that I believe in your healthy and happy return." I hide it in my neck pouch.

The inconspicuous piece of jewelry becomes a miraculous treasure to me through all dangers. I wear it over my heart and know that Mother, when her hands shaped it, wove a wish deep into it.

In captivity, which concludes the end of the fight, much is taken from me, but my treasure remains untouched.

And now, that you know everything, you will understand why it hung in my work corner in Kenedy, such that I could also see it from my bed. In the cold it warmed me, in distress it helped and healed pains. Home, Mother, and many memories lie enclosed in it.

And where is it now, you will ask. Yes, I cannot show it to you. I gave it to a comrade in the middle of the year, a man from Lübeck, who was driving home, so that he lays it in Mother's hands, to give her certainty that her wish came true and I will soon return home healthy.

Now in this moment, as I sit in your circle and tell of Christmas, I see my Mom at home in the Christmas room. She will not have decorated a fir tree, but on the table stands the Soldier's Christmas Tree. Twenty-four ornaments hang on the twenty-four branch ends. On the top, however, I see mine and now Mother's treasure, matt the color, discolored by sweat and bleached by the sun. And yet it will be the dearest of all on the tree to her.

We came from North and South, from East and West, originated from different German roots, stood in a profession or were just about to be trained in one, are of different ages, each of us has own inclinations in art and literature, even our religion is not the same, and nevertheless, we belong together. The love for Germany, our mother country, binds us; the lived hours during the Second World Struggle [WWII]

let us become comrades.

And just as Christmas is celebrated in a different way in our various homelands, yet the German nature with forest and snow, the shining Christmas tree, the solemn bells, the giving love, and the glad tidings of Christ's Birth are common to us all, so may we, when God lets us travel home to Germany, probably come into different occupation zones, but common to us remain the mother tongue, the love for Germany, the memories of the past time of fighting, and the months that we spent in America behind barbed wire.

And just as the sun is born anew in the time of the Winter Solstice, and despite winter and cold moves towards a conquering Spring, so may from the deep darkness that lies today over our beloved Germany, a new German future be born and may it, like the sun, grow victoriously towards a spring of the people and nations.

May the Lord of all life bless in His goodness our people and Fatherland for this new growth. And that Peace will then move into all our hearts, which is promised to men who are of good will.